

Warrior Prep

Student Workbook

Grade 8 · Semester Elective

ISD 197 – Two Rivers High School

Name: _____ Period: _____

Teacher: _____ Year: _____

Welcome to Warrior Prep!

This workbook is your guide, notebook, and planner for the entire semester. Here is what's inside and how to get the most out of it.

Bell Ringer (every lesson)

Each lesson starts with a 5-minute bell ringer — a warm-up you begin the moment you sit down. There are three types: LAUNCH (connects to your own experience), REVIEW (retrieves what you learned last class), and ANTICIPATION (challenges you to predict or take a position). Write your response before sharing.

Planner Section (Weeks 1–18)

Starts right after this page. One page per week — use it for ALL six of your courses, not just Warrior Prep. Write assignments, tests, and projects the day they are assigned.

Cornell Notes Pages

Every lesson has a Cornell Notes page. Left column = essential questions. Right column = notes. Bottom = summary in YOUR own words. Early lessons have support built in; later lessons are yours to fill.

Vocabulary & Morphology

Each lesson has a Word Focus box with the word's etymology (its roots). Learning word roots helps you understand and remember new vocabulary — and figure out words you've never seen.

Readings & Comprehension Questions

Every lesson includes a reading passage and five questions. Annotate as you read using your symbols (* important, ? question, ! surprising, → connection, circle = vocabulary). Answer questions in complete sentences.

Exit Tickets

The last box in each lesson is your exit ticket. Complete it before or at the end of class. Formats vary — quick writes, 3-2-1s, sentence stems, vocabulary checks, and more.

Pre-Tests & Post-Tests

Each unit starts with a pre-test (NOT graded for correctness) and ends with a post-test. Together they show how far you've grown over the unit.

AVID CORNELL NOTES — HOW THEY WORK

LEFT COLUMN (Questions/Cues)	RIGHT COLUMN (Notes)	BOTTOM (Summary)
Essential questions, key terms, cues. Fill in DURING or right AFTER notes.	Main notes, facts, ideas, examples. In your OWN words. Leave space to add later.	3–5 sentences after the lesson. NO peeking! Your words only.

Your Semester Planner

Use ONE page per week. On Week 1, write your six course names in the Course column. Carry those names forward each week. Record every assignment, test, or deadline on the day it is ASSIGNED — not the day it is due. Check your planner at the start and end of every period.

- Write the assignment and due date.
- ✓ = done → = carried forward
- Color-code by subject if helpful.
- Keep this with you all day — not just in Warrior Prep.

Week 1					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1: _____					
Course 2: _____					
Course 3: _____					
Course 4: _____					
Course 5: _____					
Course 6: _____					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 2					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 3					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 4					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 5					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 6					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 7					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 8					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 9					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 10		Dates: _____			
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 11					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 12					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 13					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 14					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 15					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 16					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 17					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Week 18					
Dates: _____					
Course	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Course 1					
Course 2					
Course 3					
Course 4					
Course 5					
Course 6					
Weekly Goals / Notes / Carry-Forward					

Unit 1

Executive Functioning

In this unit you will explore what executive functioning means, why it matters for school and life, and how high-performing students develop the habits and strategies that help them stay organized, focused, and in control of their learning.

Unit Vocabulary

Executive Functioning — The mental skills — including working memory, flexible thinking, and self-control — that help you manage yourself and your work.

Metacognition — Thinking about your own thinking; being aware of how you learn and monitoring your understanding.

Self-Regulation — The ability to manage your emotions, impulses, and behavior in order to reach a goal.

Prioritize — To decide which tasks are most important and should be done first.

Unit 1: Executive Functioning — PRE-TEST

Directions: Answer as completely as you can RIGHT NOW. This is NOT graded for correctness — it shows your starting point. Be honest!

1. In your own words, what do you think 'executive functioning' means?

2. Describe TWO strategies you currently use to stay organized at school.

3. When you have three assignments due on the same day, how do you decide what to do first?

4. What do you do when you feel distracted or overwhelmed with schoolwork?

5. On a scale of 1–5, rate your current organizational skills. Explain your rating.

LAUNCH

Brain Warm-Up

Write your answer: In the last 24 hours, name ONE moment when you had to stop yourself from doing something you wanted to do in order to do something you needed to do. What made it hard?

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	10 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 1.1 — What Is Executive Functioning? · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Executive Functioning	<i>Etymology: Latin executivus (to carry out) + Latin functio (performance)</i>	The mental skills that help you manage yourself, your tasks, and your goals — like the 'CEO' of your brain.
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QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What are EF skills? • Why does EF matter in school? • Which EF skill is hardest for me? • What part of the brain controls EF? Your own questions: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	Executive Functioning (EF) = mental skills that help us PLAN, FOCUS, REMEMBER, and MANAGE behavior. Key EF Skills: • Working Memory — holding info in your mind while using it • Cognitive Flexibility — shifting between tasks or ideas • Inhibitory Control — stopping impulses; staying on task • Planning & Organization — breaking tasks into steps • Time Management — estimating & using time well • Emotional Regulation — managing frustration, stress Location in the brain: PREFRONTAL CORTEX (front of brain) — still developing until age 25! High-performing students USE these skills intentionally — they are LEARNABLE. Continue your notes below: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 1.1 · Reading: The CEO of Your Brain

Source: Adapted from neuroscience research on adolescent brain development

■ Listen: reading_EN_1.1.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Every large company has a CEO — a Chief Executive Officer who sets priorities, manages people, solves problems, and keeps the whole organization moving toward its goals. Your brain has something similar. Nestled right behind your forehead is a region called the prefrontal cortex, and its job is to do exactly what a CEO does: plan, organize, make decisions, regulate emotions, and keep you focused on what matters.

Scientists call the skills managed by the prefrontal cortex executive functions. These include working memory (holding information in your mind while you use it), cognitive flexibility (shifting between tasks or ideas), inhibitory control (stopping impulses and staying on task), planning and organization (breaking big goals into steps), time management (estimating how long things take), and emotional regulation (managing frustration, anxiety, and stress so they don't derail you).

Here is something that surprises many people: the prefrontal cortex does not fully develop until about age 25. That means you are literally working with a brain that is still under construction. This is not a weakness — it is an opportunity. Research consistently shows that executive functioning skills are not fixed at birth. They are learnable. Every time you practice organizing your materials, planning ahead, or pushing through a frustrating problem, you are actually strengthening the neural pathways associated with those skills.

The students who tend to thrive in challenging high school courses — and later in college and careers — are not always the ones with the highest natural ability. They are the ones who have developed strong executive functioning habits. They write things down instead of trusting memory. They break big projects into smaller steps. They know their own distractors and have strategies for managing them. They ask for help before they fall too far behind. These are learnable behaviors, and this course exists to help you build them.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. According to the reading, what is the prefrontal cortex and what does it do?

2. List FOUR executive functioning skills described in the reading. For each one, write your own example of how it shows up in a student's daily life.

3. The reading says the prefrontal cortex 'doesn't fully develop until age 25.' What does this mean for you as an 8th grader — is this a problem or an opportunity? Use evidence from the text.

4. What do high-performing students do differently, according to the reading? List at least **THREE** specific behaviors.

5. The reading compares the brain's CEO to a company CEO. Do you think this is a good comparison? What does it help explain — and what might it leave out?

"The Group Chat at 11:47 PM"

■ Listen: story_EN_1.1.m4a

Maya stared at her planner. She'd rewritten it three times since dinner — the color-coded version, then the bullet-point version, then back to color-coded. It was 11:47 PM. She had a math test in the morning. She had not studied for it yet.

Her phone lit up. Jordan: "anyone else still awake lol"

Priya: "unfortunately"

Eli: "yeah. watching film. coach sent it at 11. should i even study"

Maya typed: "I haven't started."

Jordan: "MAYA. you. haven't started. are you ok"

"I was doing the planner," she typed. Then deleted it. Too embarrassing. She typed it again and sent it anyway.

A pause. Then Jordan: "bro i didn't even know we had a test"

"Jordan."

"what. i know the stuff. i'll be fine."

Priya sent a photo — two pages of handwritten notes, organized by section, with margin questions she'd written to herself. Maya felt her stomach drop. That was what studying looked like. That was not what she had done.

Eli: "how long do you guys actually study for one test"

Nobody answered. Maya thought about it honestly. She spent two hours on her planner and twenty minutes looking at her notes. That didn't feel like the right thing to say.

"Eli, just do thirty minutes," Priya finally wrote. "Anything is better than nothing."

"yeah ok"

Maya put her phone face-down. She opened her math notes. Her planner, finished and color-coded and useless, sat next to her textbook.

She knew how to look organized. She was less sure she knew how to actually get things done.

The clock said 11:53 PM.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Maya spent two hours on her planner and only twenty minutes studying. What does that tell you about the difference between being organized and being effective?

2. Jordan says he 'knows the stuff' and will be fine. Is that executive functioning? What skill is he skipping?

3. Priya has notes with margin questions. What does that suggest about how she approaches learning — not just memorizing?

4. Which of these four students do you most recognize — in yourself or in someone you know? What would you tell them?

Unit 1 · Lesson 1.1 — What Is Executive Functioning?

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Define executive functioning and name at least four EF skills.
- Explain why EF skills matter for school success.
- Identify your current strengths and growth areas using an EF self-assessment.

The CEO of Your Brain

Imagine your brain is a company. The prefrontal cortex is the CEO — it makes decisions, manages time, and keeps everyone on track. Executive functioning is the collection of skills that CEO uses every single day. The great news: these skills are not fixed. They grow with practice, just like a muscle.

EF Self-Assessment

Rate yourself honestly on each skill below (1 = I struggle here, 5 = I've got this).

I remember to bring the right materials to class.	■	■	■	■	■
I start assignments without being reminded.	■	■	■	■	■
I break big projects into smaller steps.	■	■	■	■	■
I can shift focus when plans change.	■	■	■	■	■
I manage my frustration when school gets hard.	■	■	■	■	■
I estimate how long tasks will take.	■	■	■	■	■
I keep my backpack and binder organized.	■	■	■	■	■
I ask for help when I am confused.	■	■	■	■	■

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 1.1: What Is Executive Functioning?

Choose ONE executive functioning skill from today's lesson. Explain what it means and describe a real situation — from school, sports, or daily life — where that skill helped you (or where it could have helped you).

REVIEW

EF Skill Quick-Sort

Without looking at your notes — name THREE executive functioning skills from last class. Then: rank them from easiest to hardest to use. Be ready to explain your ranking.

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 1.2 — Organization & Planning · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Prioritize

*Etymology: Latin prior (first, more important)
+ -ize (to make/do)*

To rank tasks by importance and urgency so the most critical work gets done first.

QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What is the difference between urgent and important? • How does the Eisenhower Matrix work? • What goes in a planner? • How does planning reduce stress? Your own questions:	TWO TYPES OF ORGANIZATION: 1. Physical organization — binder, locker, backpack, supplies 2. Cognitive organization — knowing WHAT to do and WHEN THE EISENHOWER MATRIX — sorting tasks into 4 boxes: URGENT + IMPORTANT → Do it NOW NOT urgent + IMPORTANT → Schedule it URGENT + NOT important → Delegate or minimize NOT urgent + NOT important → Eliminate PLANNER BASICS: • Write every assignment the day it is given • Include the DUE DATE, not just the assignment • Check your planner at the START and END of every class • Use your Warrior Prep planner pages daily Continue your notes below:

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 1.2 · Reading: The Art of Getting Things Done: Organization and Prioritization

Source: Adapted from research on student academic planning

■ Listen: reading_EN_1.2.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Open any successful student's backpack and you will usually find a system: color-coded folders, a filled-in planner, highlighted notes. But organization is not about being neat for its own sake — it is about reducing the mental energy you waste searching for things, remembering deadlines, or figuring out what to do next. When your physical and cognitive systems are in order, you free up mental bandwidth for actual learning.

One of the most powerful tools for managing schoolwork comes from an unlikely source: Dwight D. Eisenhower, the 34th President of the United States. Eisenhower was famous for making high-stakes decisions under pressure, and he developed a simple framework for sorting tasks. Every task, he argued, can be placed into one of four categories based on two questions: Is it urgent? (Does it need attention immediately?) Is it important? (Does it have significant consequences?)

Tasks that are URGENT and IMPORTANT must be done right away — a test tomorrow, an assignment due in an hour. Tasks that are NOT URGENT but IMPORTANT are the dangerous middle zone. These are projects due in three weeks, studying for an exam a month out, or building relationships with teachers. Most students ignore these tasks until they become urgent — and then they are already behind. High performers schedule these tasks before they become crises. Tasks that are URGENT but NOT IMPORTANT might feel pressing — texts, notifications, a friend's drama — but do not actually advance your goals. Tasks that are NEITHER urgent NOR important (endless scrolling, procrastinating) should simply be eliminated from your study time.

Your planner is not just a place to write down homework. It is a tool for making Eisenhower-style decisions visible. When you write every assignment on the day it is given (not the day it is due), you can see the week ahead of you and make intentional choices about where to spend your time. The students who use planners consistently report lower stress, higher grades, and more free time — because they do not waste energy trying to remember what they are supposed to be doing.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is the difference between being 'organized' and being 'organized for learning'? Use the reading to support your answer.

2. Explain the Eisenhower Matrix in your own words. Draw the four quadrants and label them.

3. The reading calls 'not urgent but important' tasks a 'dangerous middle zone.' Why are these tasks dangerous? Give a school example.

4. Why does the reading say you should write assignments on the day they are GIVEN, not the day they are DUE? Do you currently do this? Explain.

5. Think about your own organizational habits. Which quadrant of the Eisenhower Matrix do you spend the most time in? Which quadrant do you need to spend more time in?

"The Stack"

■ Listen: story_EN_1.2.m4a

The stack on Eli's desk had been there since Tuesday. He knew exactly what was in it: a history worksheet (due yesterday), a permission slip for the science field trip (due last week, trip already gone), a reading response he'd started and abandoned, and a math corrections sheet that might still count for partial credit if he turned it in.

He knew all of this. He did not move the stack.

Jordan came over after practice and immediately picked up the permission slip. "Dude. The field trip was last Wednesday."

"I know."

"You didn't go?"

"No."

Jordan put it down carefully, like it might be radioactive. "What happened?"

Eli shrugged. He didn't have a good answer. He'd meant to turn it in. He'd thought about turning it in every day for two weeks. But it was never the most urgent thing, and then it was too late, and now it was just embarrassing, so the stack stayed.

"What's this one?" Jordan held up the math corrections.

"Might still count."

"Might?"

"I have to ask. I don't want to ask."

Jordan sat down. He didn't say anything for a minute. Then: "I've got like four things at home just like this. Stuff I could fix, but I'd have to explain why I didn't do it, and that's worse than just not doing it."

"Yeah," Eli said.

"So what do we do."

Eli looked at the stack. He thought about picking it up. He didn't.

"I don't know," he said. "Not this."

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Eli knows what's in the stack and what needs to happen. Why doesn't he act on it? What is getting in the way?

2. Jordan admits he has the same pattern at home. Why do you think they've both let things pile up instead of dealing with them one at a time?

3. What is the difference between a task that is urgent and one that is important? Where does the math corrections sheet fit?

4. What would it take for Eli to actually start on the stack tonight? What's the smallest possible first step?

Unit 1 · Lesson 1.2 — Organization & Planning

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Explain the difference between being organized and being organized *for learning*.
- Apply a prioritization strategy (Eisenhower Matrix) to a real assignment list.
- Set up and begin using the Warrior Prep planner system.

Urgent vs. Important — What's the Difference?

URGENT tasks demand your attention right now (they have a close deadline). IMPORTANT tasks have high value and consequences if ignored — but they may not feel pressing. Many students only react to urgent things and never get to the important ones. High-performing students learn to schedule important work before it becomes urgent.

Practice: Sort Your Tasks

Look at the assignment list below. Draw the Eisenhower Matrix and place each task in the correct box. Then answer: What should you do first? Why?

Draw the Eisenhower Matrix here: 4 quadrants (Urgent/Important, Not Urgent/Important, Urgent/Not Important, Not Urgent/Not Important). Place each numbered task below in the correct quadrant.

1. Math test — tomorrow
2. Social studies project — due in 3 weeks
3. Clean out your locker
4. Reply to a friend's text
5. Read 10 pages of your English novel — due Friday
6. Watch a TV show
7. Study for a quiz — next class period
8. Pick a topic for your science fair project — due in 6 weeks

Planner Set-Up

Turn to Week 1 in your Warrior Prep planner. Write in your 6 course names. Then record any assignments or tests you already know about in the correct day/course box.

— EXIT TICKET · Lesson 1.2: Organization & Planning

Rate how organized you felt TODAY (1 = not at all, 5 = very organized). Then explain: What is ONE specific thing you will do differently this week to improve your organization?

1 Not at all	2	3 Somewhat	4	5 Absolutely
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ANTICIPATION

Myth or Fact?

Agree or Disagree — write your answer AND your reason:

'I can study while watching a show and still remember what I studied just as well as if I'd studied in silence.'

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	10 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 1.3 — Working Memory & Focus · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Metacognition	<i>Etymology: Greek meta (beyond/about) + Latin cognitio (knowledge, understanding)</i>	Thinking about your own thinking — noticing when you are confused, distracted, or need a different strategy.
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QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What is working memory? • Why does chunking help? • What are my biggest distractors? • How can I design my environment for focus? Your own questions: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	WORKING MEMORY = mental 'scratchpad' — holds ~4 items at once — Limited capacity: overload → mistakes, forgetting, frustration STRATEGIES TO SUPPORT WORKING MEMORY: • Brain Dump — write everything you need to remember on paper BEFORE starting • Chunking — group information into meaningful units (e.g., 555-867-5309) • One task at a time — multitasking REDUCES performance by up to 40% FOCUS STEALERS (common distractors): • Phone notifications • Background TV / music with lyrics • Hunger / fatigue • Clutter in workspace ENVIRONMENT DESIGN: — Choose WHERE you study carefully — Phone face-down or in another room = big improvement _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 1.3 · Reading: Your Brain Is Not a Multitasker

Source: Adapted from research by the American Psychological Association and MIT neuroscience

■ Listen: reading_EN_1.3.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Here is a belief that almost every student holds and that neuroscience has thoroughly disproven: the idea that you can multitask effectively. The truth is that the human brain cannot process two complex tasks simultaneously. What we call 'multitasking' is actually rapid task-switching — the brain flipping back and forth between tasks many times per minute. And every single switch has a cost.

Researchers at the American Psychological Association found that task-switching can reduce productivity by up to 40 percent. That means doing homework while watching Netflix does not just distract you a little — it can take almost twice as long and result in significantly more errors. The problem is rooted in working memory, the brain's mental scratchpad. Working memory can only hold about four items at a time. When you overload it by switching between tasks, you literally knock information out of it — which is why you read the same paragraph three times without remembering it when the TV is on.

Focus, however, can be built like a muscle. Researchers studying high-performing students, musicians, and athletes consistently find that they practice sustained, undivided attention — often called deep work. They remove distractions deliberately before starting, not after they have already lost focus. Studies show that the average person takes 23 minutes to fully regain focus after a distraction. A single phone notification — even one you choose not to answer — can cost you nearly half an hour of productive thought.

The most effective students have learned to design their environment for focus rather than willpower their way through distraction. They put their phone in another room (not face-down on the desk — researchers found that even a phone on the desk, face down, slightly impairs cognitive function because part of the brain is still resisting it). They use the 'brain dump' technique — writing down everything on their mind before starting — to clear working memory before studying. These are not personality traits. They are strategies, and they are learnable.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is the difference between 'multitasking' and 'task-switching'? Why does this distinction matter?

2. The reading says task-switching can reduce productivity by up to 40%. What does this mean in real terms for a student doing an hour of homework?

3. Explain what working memory is and why it is relevant to focus and distraction.

4. What does the reading say about a phone sitting face-down on a desk? Does this surprise you? Explain your reaction.

5. The reading says focus 'can be built like a muscle.' What does this mean, and what is ONE strategy from the reading you will try this week?

"Two Tabs"

■ Listen: story_EN_1.3.m4a

They were doing homework together at Priya's kitchen table, which had started as a good idea.

That was forty-five minutes ago. Since then: Maya had checked Instagram twice, responded to a voice message, opened a new tab about a shirt she didn't need, and read most of an article about a celebrity she wasn't even interested in. Her English essay was on paragraph two.

Priya had her headphones in. She hadn't looked up once.

Maya watched her for a moment. "How do you do that?"

Priya took out one earbud. "What."

"Just... stay in it. You haven't moved in like forty-five minutes."

Priya considered this. "My phone's in my bag. In the other room."

"Why?"

"Because if it's in the same room I check it. I don't even mean to. I just do."

Maya looked at her own phone on the table. "That's kind of extreme."

"Is it?" Priya put her earbud back in, then took it out again. "How far are you on the essay?"

A pause. "Paragraph two."

"We've been here forty-five minutes."

"I know."

Priya didn't say anything judgmental. She just pushed her phone charger to the edge of the table — not even looking at Maya, already back in her essay.

Maya picked up her phone. She put it in her bag. She put the bag on the floor. She opened her essay. Paragraph two. The cursor blinked.

She wrote one sentence. Then another. The shirt tab was still open. She closed it without looking at what it cost.

That felt harder than it should have.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Priya's solution is to put her phone in another room. Maya calls it 'extreme.' Who do you think is right — and why?

2. Maya checks her phone without meaning to. What does that tell us about how habits and environment interact?

3. The story ends without saying whether Maya finishes the essay. What do you predict happens — and what would change the outcome?

4. What is one thing in your environment that pulls your attention away from work? Could you change it? Would you?

Unit 1 · Lesson 1.3 — Working Memory & Focus

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Describe what working memory is and why it is limited.
- Apply at least two strategies (chunking, brain dump, environment design) to improve focus.
- Conduct a personal distraction audit and create an action plan.

The 40% Cost of Multitasking

Research from the American Psychological Association shows that task-switching — what we call 'multitasking' — reduces productivity by up to 40%. Your brain doesn't actually do two things at once; it rapidly switches back and forth, and each switch costs time and mental energy. For students, this means doing homework while watching TV takes almost twice as long as doing it with the TV off.

Distraction Audit

Be honest with yourself. For each distractor below, circle how often it affects your study time. Then choose your #1 distractor and write a plan to address it.

Phone / social media	■	■	■	■
TV / streaming in the background	■	■	■	■
Music with lyrics	■	■	■	■
Noise from family / roommates	■	■	■	■
Hunger	■	■	■	■
Fatigue / sleepiness	■	■	■	■
Clutter / disorganized workspace	■	■	■	■
Anxiety or stress	■	■	■	■

My #1 distractor: _____ **My plan to address it:**

⇒ **EXIT TICKET · Lesson 1.3: Working Memory & Focus**

3 things I learned today about working memory or focus:

2 strategies I will try this week:

1 question I still have:

REVIEW

Unit 1 Vocabulary Lightning Round

Without your workbook: write the definition of EACH word in your own words.

1. Executive functioning 2. Inhibitory control 3. Working memory 4. Cognitive flexibility

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	6 min	8 min	13 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 1.4 — Self-Regulation & Goal-Setting · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Self-Regulation	<i>Etymology: Latin se (oneself) + Latin regulare (to control, to rule)</i>	The ability to manage your own emotions, thoughts, and behavior to work toward a goal, even when things are difficult.
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QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What is self-regulation? • What does SMART stand for? • How do I monitor my own progress? • What do I do when I fall off track? Your own questions: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	SELF-REGULATION = managing yourself to reach a goal — Includes: delaying gratification, managing frustration, staying persistent THE SMART GOAL FRAMEWORK: S — Specific: What exactly will I do? M — Measurable: How will I know I achieved it? A — Achievable: Is it realistic for me right now? R — Relevant: Does it matter to my life/school goals? T — Time-bound: By when will I achieve it? WEAK goal: 'I want to do better in math.' SMART goal: 'I will earn a B or higher on my next three math tests by studying for 20 minutes every other day using flashcards. I will check my grade in Infinite Campus each Friday.' MONITORING: Check in on your goal every week — what's working? what needs to change? _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 1.4 · Reading: The Science of Willpower — and Why Goals Beat Willpower Every Time

Source: Adapted from research by Dr. Carol Dweck, Walter Mischel, and Angela Duckworth

■ Listen: reading_EN_1.4.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

In the 1960s, a Stanford psychologist named Walter Mischel ran an experiment that became one of the most famous in all of psychology. He placed young children in front of a marshmallow and gave them a choice: eat it now, or wait 15 minutes and get two. Years later, Mischel tracked down those same children as teenagers and adults. The ones who had waited, he found, had higher SAT scores, better social skills, and lower rates of substance abuse. The experiment seemed to prove that self-control was the key to success.

But here is what later researchers discovered that changed everything: the children who waited successfully were not simply born with more willpower. They used strategies. They covered their eyes so they couldn't see the marshmallow. They sang songs. They pretended the marshmallow was a picture, not real food. Self-regulation, it turns out, is not a fixed trait — it is a skill that depends heavily on having effective strategies and a supportive environment.

Psychologist Angela Duckworth's research on 'grit' — the combination of passion and perseverance for long-term goals — confirms this. The most successful people she studied were not those who relied on raw willpower to grind through everything. They were people who had clear, meaningful goals that motivated them through difficulty. A goal gives your effort direction. Without a goal, every challenge feels like a reason to quit. With a goal, the same challenge becomes evidence that you are doing something hard and worthwhile.

The SMART goal framework — Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound — exists because vague intentions rarely become real action. 'I want to do better in math' is an intention. 'I will earn a B or higher on my next three math tests by studying for 20 minutes every other day using practice problems' is a SMART goal. The difference is accountability: you know exactly what success looks like, and you can track your progress week by week. Research shows that people who write down their goals are significantly more likely to achieve them than those who keep goals only in their heads.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. Describe the marshmallow experiment in your own words. What did researchers originally conclude from it?

2. What did later researchers discover that changed the interpretation of the marshmallow study? Why is this distinction important?

3. According to Angela Duckworth's research, what do the most successful people have in common? How is this different from just having willpower?

4. Compare these two goals: 'I want to get better grades' vs. 'I will earn a B+ or higher in science this semester by reviewing my notes for 15 minutes after every class.' Which is SMART? Explain each element.

5. Write your OWN SMART goal for this semester. It must be school-related. Make sure all five elements (S, M, A, R, T) are clearly present.

"The Goal That Wasn't"

■ Listen: story_EN_1.4.m4a

Their advisor had them write goals at the start of the semester. Jordan wrote: Get better grades.

He'd been looking at it for four months. It still said *Get better grades*. His grades had not gotten better.

In Warrior Prep, the teacher asked them to take out that goal and read it.

"Mine's embarrassing," Jordan said, showing Maya.

She read it. "What does 'better' mean?"

"Like... higher."

"Higher than what? By how much? In which class? By when?"

Jordan stared at her. "You sound like a lawyer."

"I'm serious. How would you know if you hit it?"

He thought about it. He genuinely did not know. The goal had felt real when he wrote it. It had felt like wanting something. But wanting something and having a plan for it were different things, and he hadn't thought about that until right now.

Eli was looking at his goal too. He'd written: Stay on top of things.

"Yours is the same," Maya said.

"I know."

"What does 'on top of things' look like on a Tuesday?"

Eli put his paper face-down.

Maya looked at her own goal. She'd written two full sentences, with a specific class, a specific grade target, and a self-check date. She'd thought it was good. Now she wasn't sure if she'd actually done anything toward it or just written it carefully and felt satisfied.

"I think mine might be fake too," she said quietly. "I hit the checkpoints but I don't know if anything actually changed."

Nobody had a great answer for that.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Jordan's goal is 'get better grades.' What's missing? What would make it a real SMART goal?

2. Maya wrote a specific, well-crafted goal — but still questions whether she actually worked toward it. What's the difference between writing a good goal and acting on one?

3. Eli puts his paper face-down. What do you think he's feeling? Why is that reaction understandable — and also a problem?

4. Write a one-sentence goal for this semester that is specific enough that you'd be able to tell on the last day of school whether you hit it or not.

Unit 1 · Lesson 1.4 — Self-Regulation & Goal-Setting

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Define self-regulation and explain its connection to academic success.
- Write a SMART goal using the full framework.
- Create a monitoring plan to track progress on their SMART goal.

The Marshmallow Test — and What It Really Means

In a famous study, young children were given a marshmallow and told they could eat it now, or wait 15 minutes and get two. Researchers found that children who waited tended to have better academic outcomes later in life. But the real lesson isn't that some people are born with willpower — it's that strategies matter. The children who waited successfully used distraction techniques and mental tricks. Self-regulation is a skill, not a personality trait.

Write Your SMART Goal

Use the template below to write ONE SMART goal you will work on for the rest of this semester. This goal should relate to school — grades, habits, organization, or a specific subject.

S – Specific (*What exactly will I do?*)

M – Measurable (*How will I measure success?*)

A – Achievable (*Why is this realistic for me right now?*)

R – Relevant (*Why does this matter to me?*)

T – Time-bound (*I will achieve this by:*)

⇒ **EXIT TICKET · Lesson 1.4: Self-Regulation & Goal-Setting**

Match each term to its definition. Then use TWO of the terms in a sentence that connects to your own life.

Self-regulation	Thinking about your own thinking and learning
SMART goal	A goal that is Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound
Metacognition	Managing your emotions and behavior to reach a goal
Executive functioning	Mental skills that help you plan, focus, and manage yourself

Write *TWO* terms in sentences:

Unit 1: Executive Functioning — POST-TEST

Directions: Revisit the five questions from your pre-test. Answer each question again — you may use more detail and vocabulary from this unit. Then write 3–5 sentences describing the most important change you plan to make in how you manage your learning.

Unit 2

Career Pathways at Two Rivers

In this unit you will explore the six Minnesota career fields and the CTE pathways available at Two Rivers High School. Through reading activities and reflection, you will connect your interests to real courses and experiences you can pursue starting in 9th grade.

Unit Vocabulary

Career Pathway — A sequence of courses, experiences, and skills that prepares a person for a specific group of careers.

CTE (Career & Technical Education) — Courses and programs that combine academic learning with real-world technical and career skills.

Internship — A supervised, hands-on learning experience within a workplace or professional setting.

Cluster — A group of related careers organized around common knowledge and skills.

Unit 2: Career Pathways at Two Rivers — PRE-TEST

Directions: Answer as completely as you can RIGHT NOW. This is NOT graded for correctness — it shows your starting point. Be honest!

1. Name THREE jobs or careers you are curious about. Why do they interest you?

2. What is a 'career pathway'? Explain in your own words.

3. What does CTE stand for, and what do you think those courses involve?

4. Have you ever thought about what you might study in high school or beyond? Describe your current thinking.

5. What questions do you have about the courses available at Two Rivers High School?

LAUNCH

Career Assumption Check

Respond quickly — don't overthink:

Name one career you think you might be interested in someday. NOW: where does that career fit in school? What courses at Two Rivers connect to it?

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 2.1 — Minnesota Career Fields & Pathways · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Career Pathway	<i>Etymology: Latin carrera (road, course) + Old English paþ (path, track)</i>	A sequence of related courses, experiences, and skills that leads toward a specific group of careers.
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QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What are the 6 MN career fields? • What is the difference between a field, a cluster, and a pathway? • Which field matches my interests? • How are pathways connected to HS courses? Your own questions: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	MINNESOTA'S 6 CAREER FIELDS: 1. Engineering, Manufacturing & Technology 2. Health Sciences Technology 3. Arts, Communications & Information Systems 4. Business, Management & Administration 5. Human Services 6. Agriculture, Food & Natural Resources STRUCTURE (from broad → specific): Career FIELD → Career CLUSTER → Career PATHWAY Example: Business (field) → Finance (cluster) → Accounting (pathway) TWO RIVERS connects its courses to these fields — that means the classes you choose in HS can prepare you for the career field you're interested in. _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 2.1 · Reading: Finding Your Path: Minnesota's Career Fields and What They Mean for You

Source: Adapted from the Minnesota Department of Education Career Fields, Clusters & Pathways Framework

■ Listen: reading_EN_2.1.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Every job that exists — from brain surgeon to video game designer to farmer to social worker — fits somewhere in a larger map. The Minnesota Department of Education has organized all careers into six broad career fields. These fields are not rigid boxes; they are organizing tools that help students connect their interests to real courses, real experiences, and real futures. Understanding the map makes it easier to find your direction.

Within each field, careers are organized into clusters — groups of related industries and occupations that share common knowledge and skills. Within each cluster, careers are further organized into pathways — the specific roads that lead from school through training to a particular career. Think of it like a set of Russian nesting dolls: the career field is the outer layer, the cluster is the middle, and the pathway is the specific destination inside.

Minnesota's six career fields are: Engineering, Manufacturing & Technology; Health Sciences Technology; Arts, Communications & Information Systems; Business, Management & Administration; Human Services; and Agriculture, Food & Natural Resources. Each field represents a broad category of work that shapes our communities and economy. Every student's interests connect to at least one of these fields — often several.

Here is why this matters for you right now: Two Rivers High School has designed its courses to connect directly to these six fields. When you take Woodworking I, you are exploring the Engineering & Technology field. When you take Drawing or Digital Music Production, you are exploring Arts & Communications. When you take Child Psychology, you are entering the Human Services pathway. Your elective choices in high school are not random — they can be the beginning of a career path. The students who use high school most effectively treat each course as an exploration, not just a requirement.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What are Minnesota's six career fields? List all six from memory, then check the reading.

2. Explain the relationship between a career field, a career cluster, and a career pathway. Use the Russian nesting dolls analogy in your explanation.

3. The reading says students' interests 'connect to at least one of these fields — often several.' Look at the six fields. Which TWO connect most to your interests right now? Explain your reasoning.

4. The reading says 'elective choices in high school can be the beginning of a career path.' Do you agree with this idea? Does it change how you think about choosing electives?

5. Choose ONE specific course from Two Rivers you know about. Which career field does it connect to? Explain the connection.

"What Do You Want to Be"

■ Listen: story_EN_2.1.m4a

The school counselor came to homeroom with a worksheet. At the top it said: CAREER INTEREST INVENTORY.

Jordan finished it in four minutes. He checked: Work with people. Outdoors sometimes. Not a lot of reading. Something that matters. The results said: Social Worker, Landscape Architect, Athletic Trainer.

He put it in his folder.

Priya was still on page one. She kept going back and changing her answers.

"Just pick one," Jordan said.

"What if I pick wrong?"

"It's not a test."

"It feels like one." She erased something again. "What did yours say?"

Jordan showed her. She looked at it for a long time.

"Athletic trainer is interesting," she said.

"I don't actually know what that is."

"It's like... the person on the sideline who wraps ankles and figures out if someone got a concussion. And works with physical therapists."

Jordan looked at the paper with new interest. "How do you know that?"

"My mom's a physical therapist."

"Priya. I've known you for two years. I did not know that."

She shrugged. Then, more quietly: "There's a CAPS program at Two Rivers. Health and medicine. I looked it up."

"Why didn't you sign up?"

A long pause. She looked at her still-unfinished worksheet. "I don't know if I'm the kind of person who gets into something like that."

Jordan didn't know what to say to that. The bell rang. He kept thinking about it for the rest of the day.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Priya says she doesn't know if she's 'the kind of person' who gets into the CAPS program. What does she mean — and what might be getting in her way?

2. Jordan checked off interests without thinking too hard. Priya agonized over every answer. Which approach do you think is more useful for a career interest inventory — and why?

3. Jordan didn't know his friend's parent was a physical therapist after two years. What does that suggest about how well we know the people around us — including their career connections?

4. Is there a career or program you've looked up but talked yourself out of? What stopped you?

Unit 2 · Lesson 2.1 — Minnesota Career Fields & Pathways

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Name and describe the six Minnesota career fields.
- Explain the relationship between career fields, clusters, and pathways.
- Identify at least one career field that matches your interests.

Reading: Minnesota Career Fields at Two Rivers

Minnesota organizes all careers into six broad fields. Each field contains multiple clusters — groups of related industries. Each cluster branches into specific pathways that point toward particular jobs and college programs. Two Rivers has deliberately designed its course offerings to connect to every one of these six fields, giving you the ability to start exploring your interests in 9th grade and build toward a pathway over four years.

Activity: Career Field Inventory

Read the description of each career field below. Rate your interest in each (1 = not interested, 5 = very interested), then list one career from each field that you have heard of.

Engineering, Manufacturing & Technology	Designing, building, and maintaining systems, structures, and machines.		
Health Sciences Technology	Caring for human health — from doctors and nurses to lab technicians and researchers.		
Arts, Communications & Information Systems	Creating and communicating through art, music, media, and technology.		
Business, Management & Administration	Running organizations, managing finances, marketing products, and leading teams.		
Human Services	Supporting people through education, social work, law enforcement, and government.		
Agriculture, Food & Natural Resources	Growing food, managing land, protecting ecosystems, and sustaining natural resources.		

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 2.1: Minnesota Career Fields & Pathways

Which career field interests you MOST right now? Write 3–4 sentences explaining your choice. What careers within that field have you heard of or are curious about?

REVIEW

Career Fields Memory Map

In 2 minutes: from memory, list as many of the six Minnesota career fields as you can. Under each one, name at least ONE Two Rivers course or program that fits.

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	10 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 2.2 — STEM & Health Pathways at TRHS · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: CTE (Career & Technical Education)

Etymology: Latin carrera (course/road) + Latin technica (art, skill) + Latin educare (to lead out, to raise)

Programs that blend classroom learning with hands-on technical and career-readiness skills.

QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What Engineering/Tech courses does TRHS offer? • What Health Sciences courses are available? • What is the CAPS program? • Which of these courses interest me? Your own questions: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	ENGINEERING, MANUFACTURING & TECHNOLOGY at TRHS: Courses: Basic Auto Mechanics, Small Gas Engine Repair, Super Mileage Car Design I & II, Woodworking I-III, Printing Technology, Metals, CADD (Computer-Aided Design & Drafting), Math for the Trades CAPS Experience: Transportation & Skilled Trades (junior/senior, periods 5-6-7, off-site) HEALTH SCIENCES TECHNOLOGY at TRHS: Courses: Human Anatomy & Physiology Experiences: Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA), CAPS Healthcare & Medicine (junior/senior, off-site at South St. Paul Community Learning Center) CAPS = Career Academy Programs — year-long, immersive, include an internship _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 2.2 · Reading: Building and Healing: STEM and Health Pathways at Two Rivers

Source: Adapted from the TRHS 2026-27 Academic Planning Guide

■ Listen: reading_EN_2.2.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Some of the fastest-growing and highest-paying careers in the United States sit within two career fields: Engineering, Manufacturing & Technology and Health Sciences Technology. At Two Rivers High School, students can begin exploring both of these fields as early as 9th grade through a wide range of courses and, for older students, immersive CAPS (Career Academy Programs) experiences.

In the Engineering, Manufacturing & Technology field, Two Rivers offers courses that span a remarkable range: Computer-Aided Design and Drafting (CADD) teaches students to use industry-standard software to create precise technical drawings. Woodworking I, II, and III build skills in design, measurement, and precision work with hand and power tools. Metals teaches welding, fabrication, and metalworking. Small Gas Engine Repair and Basic Auto Mechanics introduce students to engine systems and real diagnostic work. Super Mileage Car Design challenges students to design and build a fuel-efficient vehicle for competition. These courses develop practical skills and problem-solving habits that transfer directly to engineering, trades, and technology careers.

In the Health Sciences Technology field, Human Anatomy & Physiology gives students a rigorous, college-preparatory look at how the human body works — a course that is considered foundational for any health career, from doctor to nurse to physical therapist to biomedical engineer. For motivated juniors and seniors, the Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA) program earns a professional certification that qualifies graduates for entry-level health care work.

The most immersive options in both fields are the TriDistrict CAPS programs. CAPS Transportation & Skilled Trades places students in real workplaces in the transportation industry for a half-day internship in the second semester. CAPS Healthcare & Medicine places students in a professional healthcare learning center, working alongside real healthcare providers. Both programs earn 2-3 high school credits plus additional credits in English or another core subject. They require an application, a recommendation, and a record of good attendance — because real workplaces demand exactly that.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. List at least FOUR courses Two Rivers offers in the Engineering, Manufacturing & Technology field. For each, write one sentence describing what students learn.

2. What is the Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA) program and what does it earn students?

3. What is a CAPS program? What makes it different from a regular high school course?

4. The reading says CAPS programs 'require an application, a recommendation, and a record of good attendance — because real workplaces demand exactly that.' What does this tell you about how to prepare for these opportunities starting in 9th grade?

5. Which course or program from this reading interests you most? What career does it connect to? What would you need to do to qualify for it?

"The Video"

■ Listen: story_EN_2.2.m4a

The Two Rivers website had a video about CAPS. Eli watched it during lunch, headphones in, alone at the end of a table. In it, a junior was standing in an actual auto body shop, talking about a real car he'd helped restore. He looked comfortable. He looked like he knew what he was doing.

Eli watched it twice.

Maya sat down across from him. "What are you watching?"

He turned his phone over. "Nothing."

She looked at him. He turned it back over and showed her.

She watched for a minute. "The Transportation CAPS?"

"Yeah."

"Are you thinking about it?"

"I don't know. Maybe." He put his phone down. "My uncle has a shop. I work there on weekends. I actually like it. Like, actually like it, not just saying that."

"So apply."

"It's a whole thing. You have to write something. Interview maybe."

"Eli. You literally already do this job."

"It's different."

Maya looked at him. She knew what 'it's different' meant. It meant: what if I apply and don't get in. It meant: what if I try for something real and it doesn't work.

"The application's on the planning guide," she said carefully. "It's not that long."

"I know. I looked."

"You looked."

"Yeah."

The bell rang. Eli picked up his tray. He had looked. He had the tab still open on his phone. He just hadn't done anything with it yet, and he wasn't sure when he would, or if he would, and that felt worse than not knowing about it at all.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Eli has real-world experience in exactly the CAPS field he's interested in. Why hasn't he applied?

2. Maya figures out what 'it's different' really means without Eli saying it. What does she understand that Eli isn't saying out loud?

3. What's the difference between researching something (Eli has the tab open) and actually moving toward it? What makes that gap hard to close?

4. Is there something you've already looked into but haven't acted on? What would it take to take one actual step this week?

Unit 2 · Lesson 2.2 — STEM & Health Pathways at TRHS

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Identify specific TRHS courses that connect to Engineering/Technology and Health Sciences pathways.
- Read and summarize course descriptions from the Academic Planning Guide.
- Evaluate which courses in these fields align with their interests and abilities.

Reading: Course Descriptions from the Planning Guide

Two Rivers offers a wide range of technical courses you can take as early as 9th grade. In Engineering & Technology, courses like CADD and Woodworking teach you to design, build, and problem-solve with real tools. In Health Sciences, Human Anatomy & Physiology gives you a rigorous look at how the human body works — a foundation for any health career. The CAPS (Career Academy Programs) are the most immersive option: year-long courses where you work alongside professionals and complete a real internship.

Activity: Course Connection Chart

Pick TWO courses from the list above that you find most interesting. For each one, complete the chart below using information from the Academic Planning Guide.

Course name		
Grade eligible		
What you learn		
Career connection		
My interest rating (1-5)		

— EXIT TICKET · Lesson 2.2: STEM & Health Pathways at TRHS

One course in Engineering/Technology or Health Sciences that I would consider taking is _____ because...

Something I did NOT know about TRHS course options before today is...

ANTICIPATION

What Does a Communicator Do?

Quick write: What job do you picture when you hear 'Arts, Communications, and Information Systems'? Do you think that field pays well? Do you think it's in demand? Explain your reasoning.

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	10 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 2.3 — Arts, Business & Human Services Pathways · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Internship	<i>Etymology: Latin internus (within, inside) — learning from inside an organization</i>	A supervised experience inside a professional workplace that provides real-world career training.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 2.3 · Reading: Create, Connect, Lead: Arts, Business, and Human Services at Two Rivers

Source: Adapted from the TRHS 2026-27 Academic Planning Guide

■ Listen: reading_EN_2.3.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Not every student is drawn to building engines or working in hospitals. Two Rivers High School offers equally rich pathways in the Arts, Communications & Information Systems field; Business, Management & Administration; and Human Services. These three career fields cover careers in creativity, commerce, and community — and they are more connected to each other than you might think.

The Arts, Communications & Information Systems field at Two Rivers is one of the broadest in the school. Visual artists can study Drawing, Painting, Ceramics, Sculpture, Digital Art, and AP Studio Art. Students interested in media and production can take Video Production, Mass Media Production, Intro to Photography, and Advanced Photography. Musicians can choose from Concert Band, Symphonic Band, Wind Ensemble, Concert Orchestra, Philharmonic Orchestra, or multiple choirs — and students interested in the technology of music can take Digital Music Production I & II or Music Theory. Students drawn to technology itself can take Intro to Computer Science or AP Computer Science Principles. The CAPS Computer Science & Information Technology program earns students 3 elective credits and an industry-recognized A+ certification.

The Business, Management & Administration field offers a pipeline from Introduction to Business & Entrepreneurship and Accounting I (available in 9th grade) through Personal Finance, AP Business with Personal Finance, and Sales, Marketing & School Store Management. The CAPS Business & Entrepreneurship program places juniors and seniors at Evolve Workplace in St. Paul, where they complete an actual business internship and earn 2 elective credits plus 1 English credit.

Human Services is the field focused on people: education, social work, law, government, and community support. At Two Rivers, students interested in this field can take Child Psychology, Introduction to Personal Law, Psychology, Youth Leadership, and the CIS Exploring the Teaching Profession course — which includes a supervised field experience in a real classroom at the University of Minnesota. If you care about people, justice, education, or community, this field has a pathway for you.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. List THREE specific courses from the Arts, Communications & Information Systems field that interest you. For each, write one sentence explaining why.

2. What does the CAPS Computer Science & IT program earn students, and what is an A+ certification?

3. Trace a career pathway from one of the Business courses at Two Rivers all the way to a specific career after high school. What courses would you take? What would you do after graduation?

4. The reading says Arts, Business, and Human Services are 'more connected to each other than you might think.' Can you think of an example of a career that connects at least two of these fields?

5. Which of the three fields in this reading interests you most: Arts & Communications, Business, or Human Services? Use specific details from the reading to justify your answer.

"She Drew It"

■ Listen: story_EN_2.3.m4a

The assignment was to research one career from the Arts, Communications, and Information Systems field. Jordan put *YouTuber* on his paper and then stared at the ceiling.

Priya drew something.

She drew it small, in the margin of her notes — a logo, with letters arranged in an arc, like something you'd see on a real company's signage. She didn't think about it. She just drew it.

Jordan looked over. "What is that?"

"I don't know. Just doodling."

"That looks like a real logo."

She looked at it. It did, kind of. *"Graphic design is a career,"* she said, mostly to herself.

"Yeah?"

"In the planning guide. Under ACI. You can take Digital Media Design at Two Rivers and there's also a pathway into visual communications."

"How do you know all this stuff?"

"I read the guide."

"The whole thing?"

"It's not that long."

Jordan looked at the logo again. "Priya. You should be in art."

"I'm not an art person."

"You just drew a professional logo in the margin of your homework."

She covered it with her hand. "I'm going into medicine."

"You literally said 'maybe' when I asked you last week."

"I — " She stopped. She looked at the logo again. "You can't make a living in graphic design."

"Can you not?"

She didn't answer. She didn't know, actually. She'd assumed it. She'd assumed a lot of things.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Priya says 'you can't make a living in graphic design' — but then admits she doesn't actually know that. Where do beliefs like that come from?

2. She covers the logo with her hand. What does that gesture tell you about how she feels about the drawing?

3. Jordan put 'YouTuber' on his paper without thinking. Priya discovered something real by accident. What's the difference in their processes?

4. Is there something you're good at that you've never considered as a career — because you assumed it wasn't practical? Where did that assumption come from?

Unit 2 · Lesson 2.3 — Arts, Business & Human Services Pathways

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Identify TRHS courses connected to Arts/Communications, Business/Management, and Human Services.
- Compare two different career pathways using evidence from the Academic Planning Guide.
- Articulate how their personal interests and strengths connect to one or more pathways.

Reading: Arts, Communications & Information Systems

Two Rivers has one of the broadest arts offerings in the district. Students can study visual art (drawing, painting, ceramics, sculpture, digital art, AP Studio Art), music (band, orchestra, choir, guitar, digital music production, music theory), and media (video production, mass media production, photography, journalism, yearbook). For students interested in technology and computing, Intro to Computer Science and AP Computer Science Principles are also in this pathway. The CAPS Computer Science & IT program (junior/senior) earns 3 elective credits and an industry-recognized A+ certification.

Reading: Business, Management & Administration

Students interested in business can start with Business & Entrepreneurship or Accounting I as early as 9th grade. Upper-level options include Personal Finance, AP Business with Personal Finance, and Sales, Marketing & School Store Management. The CAPS Business & Entrepreneurship program (junior/senior, at Evolve Workplace in St. Paul) earns 2 elective credits plus 1 English credit and includes a real business internship. Family and Consumer Sciences courses (Intro to Foods, Culinary I & II, Clothing) also fit in the Business pathway.

Activity: Compare Two Pathways

Choose ANY two career pathways from Units 2.2 or 2.3. Use the Venn Diagram below to compare them. Consider: types of courses, types of careers, skills needed, and whether you can earn college credit.

Venn Diagram: Pathway 1: _____ vs. Pathway 2: _____ Draw two overlapping circles. List differences in outer sections, similarities in the overlap.

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 2.3: Arts, Business & Human Services Pathways

After exploring three career fields today, rate how clear you feel about your own interests (1 = very unclear, 5 = very clear). Then explain: Which pathway feels most 'like you' and why?

1 Not at all	2	3 Somewhat	4	5 Absolutely
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REVIEW

Two Rivers Pathway Recap

Draw a quick web/mind map from memory: put 'Two Rivers HS' in the center. Branch out to every pathway, program, or field we've studied so far. Add at least one course or career under each.

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 2.4 — Ag, Food & Natural Resources — and Planning My Path · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Cluster	<i>Etymology: Old English clyster (bunch, group) — a group of related things organized together</i>	In career planning, a cluster is a group of related occupations built around common knowledge and skills.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 2.4 · Reading: From the Ground Up: Agriculture, Food, Natural Resources — and Planning Your Path

Source: Adapted from the TRHS 2026-27 Academic Planning Guide and MDE Career Frameworks

■ Listen: [reading_EN_2.4.m4a](#)

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Soil. Water. Food. Air. These are not abstract concerns — they are the foundation of every human life on earth. The Agriculture, Food & Natural Resources career field encompasses careers that many students have never considered: conservation scientists, organic farmers, environmental engineers, food scientists, water quality specialists, sustainability coordinators, and more. In a world facing climate change, food insecurity, and environmental degradation, these careers are increasingly critical.

At Two Rivers, the entry point into this field is AP Environmental Science — a college-level course that explores the interrelationships between human activity and natural systems. Students investigate real environmental problems, conduct field studies, and prepare for a College Board exam that can earn college credit. For students who want to go deeper, the CAPS Natural Resources, Sustainability & Food Systems program is one of the most distinctive offerings in the entire district. Co-taught by a chemistry and agriculture teacher, it meets at Dodge Nature Center in West St. Paul. Students explore soil science, food systems, water chemistry, and sustainable agriculture through hands-on labs and field work — and complete a second-semester internship with a local community partner. The course earns 2 elective credits and 1 Chemistry credit.

Now that you have explored all six career fields and the specific courses and programs available at Two Rivers, you are ready to think about your own path. Career planning at 13 or 14 does not mean deciding what you will do for the rest of your life — research shows that most people change careers several times. What it does mean is making intentional choices about the experiences you seek, the courses you take, and the skills you build. Every course you choose in high school is a small vote for the kind of person you are becoming.

The most effective approach to high school course selection is what counselors call 'exploring with purpose': you pick electives that connect to genuine interests, you try things you have never tried before, and you pay attention to what energizes you versus what drains you. The goal is not to have your entire career figured out by 9th grade. The goal is to walk out of Two Rivers with a clearer sense of your strengths, your interests, and your direction — and with the academic foundation to pursue whatever path you choose.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What kinds of careers are in the Agriculture, Food & Natural Resources field? List at least four from the reading.

2. Describe the CAPS Natural Resources, Sustainability & Food Systems program. What makes it unusual compared to a regular high school course?

3. The reading says career planning at 13-14 'does not mean deciding what you will do for the rest of your life.' What does it mean, according to the author?

4. What is 'exploring with purpose' and how is it different from just picking random electives?

5. After reading about all six career fields in Unit 2, write a paragraph describing your current career thinking. Which field interests you most? What specific course or program at Two Rivers would help you explore it? What do you still not know about yourself that you need to figure out?

"The Planning Guide"

■ Listen: story_EN_2.4.m4a

Maya had tabbed hers. Color-coded tabs, naturally — pink for graduation requirements, yellow for electives, blue for CAPS, green for activities.

Jordan's was still in the envelope from when they'd handed it out three weeks ago.

They were supposed to spend the class period finding two courses they were interested in. Jordan opened his for the first time and immediately felt a familiar quiet panic — not loud enough to name, just heavy enough to make him want to look at his phone.

"How many pages is this," he said.

"One twenty-three," Maya said, without looking up.

"That's not a planning guide. That's a novel."

Priya had it open to the CAPS section. She was reading about graphic design concentrations. She hadn't told anyone she was doing that.

Eli was looking at page 44. It was the agriculture and natural resources page. He didn't have any particular reason to be looking at it. He just was.

"Eli, what career field?" Maya asked.

"I don't know. Transportation, I think."

"Did you check prerequisites?"

He had not. He looked. There was a prerequisites section. He read it slowly.

"I'd need to take Intro to Technology," he said. "Or already have shop experience."

"Do you have shop experience?"

"I work in my uncle's shop."

"Then you probably qualify."

He read the sentence again. Students with documented work-based or vocational experience may petition for prerequisite equivalency.

He'd never petitioned for anything. He wasn't sure how. But the sentence was there, and it said he might be able to, and that felt like a door he hadn't known existed.

Jordan was still on page three.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Jordan's planning guide is still in the envelope. Eli's is open to a page he landed on by chance. What does each approach cost them?

2. Eli finds a sentence that might change his options — but only because he stopped to actually read carefully. What habit made that possible?

3. Priya is researching graphic design quietly, not telling anyone. Why might she be keeping that private — and should she be?

4. What is the difference between skimming a resource and actually using it? Which one have you been doing with the Academic Planning Guide?

Unit 2 · Lesson 2.4 — Ag, Food & Natural Resources — and Planning My Path

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Identify courses and CAPS experiences in the Agriculture/Natural Resources field.
- Synthesize learning from all four career lessons into a personal interest reflection.
- Articulate a potential career field direction and the first TRHS course they would take to explore it.

Reading: Agriculture, Food & Natural Resources at TRHS

This field may be smaller in course offerings at Two Rivers, but its CAPS program is one of the most unique. The CAPS Natural Resources, Sustainability & Food Systems program is co-taught by a chemistry and agriculture teacher at Dodge Nature Center in West St. Paul. Students explore soil science, food systems, water quality, and sustainable agriculture through hands-on labs and fieldwork — and complete a second-semester internship. The course earns 2 elective credits plus 1 Chemistry credit. AP Environmental Science is also a strong option within this field.

Activity: My Career Pathway Reflection

Use the prompts below to write a personal reflection on all four career pathway lessons. Use specific course names and pathway titles from the Academic Planning Guide.

The career field that interests me most is _____ because...

Within that field, a specific career I am curious about is...

At Two Rivers, I could explore this field by taking... (name at least 2 courses)

One CAPS or internship experience I would consider applying for is... because...

A career field I had NOT thought about before this unit but now find interesting is...

— EXIT TICKET · Lesson 2.4: Ag, Food & Natural Resources — and Planning My Path

Imagine you are writing a postcard to your future 9th-grade self. In 4–6 sentences, tell them: which career pathway you are most curious about, one course at TRHS you cannot wait to try, and one piece of advice about exploring their interests.

	To: My Future 9th-Grade Self Two Rivers High School 1897 Delaware Ave Mendota Heights, MN 55118
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Directions: Revisit your pre-test responses. Then write a paragraph (5–7 sentences) describing: which career field interests you most, at least two TRHS courses or experiences related to that field, and one CAPS program you would consider applying for and why.

Unit 3

Academic Preparation for Rigorous Courses

This unit builds the academic skills you will need to succeed in challenging high school courses and beyond. You will develop strategies for reading complex texts, writing with clarity and stamina, studying effectively, and managing long-term academic work — the exact skills that separate thriving students from struggling ones in rigorous courses.

Unit Vocabulary

Stamina — The ability to sustain effort over time without giving up; in reading/writing, the capacity to focus for extended periods.

Annotation — Writing notes, questions, and reactions directly on or near a text to deepen understanding.

Synthesis — Combining information from multiple sources or ideas to form a new, deeper understanding.

Spaced Practice — A study technique in which learning is spread out over multiple shorter sessions rather than crammed into one long session.

Unit 3: Academic Preparation for Rigorous Courses — PRE-TEST

Directions: Answer as completely as you can RIGHT NOW. This is NOT graded for correctness — it shows your starting point. Be honest!

1. Describe how you currently read a difficult text (a science article, a history chapter, etc.).

2. What do you do when you sit down to write and don't know how to start?

3. How do you study for a test? Walk us through your process step by step.

4. What is the longest piece of writing you have ever completed? How did you manage it?

5. What subject do you find most academically challenging and why?

LAUNCH

Reading Habits Honest Check

Be honest — no one is grading this:

When you read something for school that you don't find interesting, what do you actually do?

Check all that apply.

☐ Read carefully ☐ Skim it ☐ Read the first and last line of each paragraph ☐ Ask someone what it says ☐ Give up

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	11 min	7 min	9 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 3.1 — Active Reading & Annotation · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Annotation	<i>Etymology: Latin annotare (to note down) — ad (to) + notare (to mark)</i>	Writing notes, questions, reactions, and connections directly on or beside a text while reading.
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QUESTIONS / CUES	NOTES
• What is active reading? • What does a good annotation look like? • How do context clues help with vocabulary? • Why is annotating better than highlighting? Your own questions: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	PASSIVE READING: eyes move across the page, mind wanders → poor retention ACTIVE READING: you interact with the text → deep understanding ANNOTATION SYSTEM (use consistently): * = important idea ? = I don't understand this / I have a question ! = surprising or interesting → = connection to something else I know Circle = unknown vocabulary word Underline = key term or main idea Margin notes = summarize the paragraph in your own words CONTEXT CLUES — when you hit an unknown word: 1. Look at surrounding sentences for clues 2. Break the word into parts (prefix, root, suffix) 3. Substitute a guess and check if the sentence makes sense _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 3.1 · Reading: Your Brain Changes When You Read — But Only If You Do It Right

Source: Adapted from research on reading comprehension and neuroplasticity

■ Listen: reading_EN_3.1.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Neuroplasticity is the brain's ability to reorganize itself by forming new neural connections throughout life. Unlike a computer, which has fixed hardware, the human brain can actually change its physical structure in response to learning and experience. When you practice a skill repeatedly — including reading — the neural pathways associated with that skill become stronger and more efficient. This means that reading difficult texts regularly is literally reshaping your brain to think more deeply.

But not all reading is equal. Research by cognitive psychologist David Dunning (famous for the Dunning-Kruger effect) found that people consistently overestimate their comprehension when they read passively. You can move your eyes across an entire page and retain almost nothing, especially when your mind wanders. Passive reading — where you simply move your eyes across text without engaging — triggers almost no deep processing in the brain. Active reading, by contrast, forces your brain into the hard work of connecting, questioning, and interpreting.

Active reading means interacting with the text as you read. You notice when you are confused and mark it. You ask questions in the margins. You underline key ideas and write their significance in your own words. You make connections to what you already know. You challenge claims that seem incomplete or overstated. When you write in the margins of a text — a practice called annotation — you are not just marking it up. You are having a conversation with the author, and that conversation is the learning.

Active reading also builds vocabulary more effectively than any flashcard. When you encounter an unknown word in context, your brain works to infer its meaning from surrounding sentences, word roots, and prior knowledge. This process — called contextual vocabulary acquisition — creates a much richer, more durable memory for the word than memorizing a definition in isolation. In college-level and Advanced Placement courses, you will encounter complex vocabulary constantly. Building the habit of active reading now means you will be equipped to handle it.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is neuroplasticity? How does the reading connect neuroplasticity to reading?

2. What is the difference between passive reading and active reading? Give a specific example of each.

3. What is annotation and why does the reading say it is 'having a conversation with the author'?

4. What is 'contextual vocabulary acquisition'? Why is it more effective than memorizing definitions?

5. Using the annotation system from class (*, ?, !, →, circle, underline), annotate THIS reading passage. Then write a 2-sentence summary of the most important idea.

"Margin Notes"

■ Listen: story_EN_3.1.m4a

They were in the library with a science article that was nine paragraphs long and significantly less interesting than nine paragraphs should be allowed to be.

Jordan read paragraph one. He had no memory of it by paragraph two. He read paragraph two. He had no memory of paragraph one or two by paragraph three.

"How are you reading that fast," he said to Priya.

She looked up. "What?"

"You're on paragraph six. I'm on paragraph two. For the second time."

"I'm annotating."

"What does that do."

She turned her paper toward him. The margins were covered — not neatly, more like a conversation she was having with the page. An asterisk next to something that surprised her. A question mark next to a claim she wasn't sure about. Two words connected by an arrow. The word *WHY?* in a circle.

"I thought that was just for English," Jordan said.

"It's for anything you actually want to remember."

He looked at his clean, unmarked page. "I feel like writing on it is messing it up."

"It's a photocopy."

"Still."

"Jordan. Reading without doing anything is just your eyes moving. You have to make your brain talk back."

He looked at paragraph two again. He picked up his pen. He wrote a question mark next to a sentence he didn't believe. Then an asterisk next to a fact that was actually kind of interesting.

He read paragraph three. He remembered paragraphs one and two.

"That's slightly annoying," he said. "That it worked."

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Jordan's eyes move across the text but nothing sticks. Priya says 'you have to make your brain talk back.' What does that actually mean?

2. Jordan resists annotating because it feels like 'messing up' the paper. What other habits or beliefs do students have that accidentally get in the way of learning?

3. Once Jordan tries one annotation, he remembers more. Why do you think the physical act of marking the page changes what his brain does with the information?

4. What's your honest default when reading something hard for school? What would you have to change to read the way Priya reads?

Unit 3 · Lesson 3.1 — Active Reading & Annotation

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Explain the difference between passive and active reading.
- Apply a consistent annotation system to a challenging text.
- Use context clues and morphology to define unknown vocabulary.

Why Highlighting Doesn't Work

Studies show that students who highlight passages retain barely more information than students who don't. Why? Because highlighting is a passive activity — your hand moves but your brain doesn't do anything. Annotation forces you to think: 'What does this mean? Why does it matter? How does it connect to what I already know?' That thinking IS learning.

Practice: Annotate This Passage

Read the passage below. Use the annotation system from your notes. After reading, write a 2-sentence summary in the margin. "Neuroplasticity is the brain's ability to reorganize itself by forming new neural connections throughout life. Unlike a computer, which has fixed hardware, the human brain can actually change its physical structure in response to learning and experience. When you practice a skill repeatedly, the neural pathways associated with that skill become stronger and more efficient — a process sometimes described as 'neurons that fire together, wire together.' This means that the mental skills you practice in school — reading, analyzing, writing, problem-solving — are literally reshaping your brain. Every time you push through a difficult text or work through a challenging math problem, you are making yourself smarter."

Write your 2-sentence summary of the passage here:

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 3.1: Active Reading & Annotation

3 annotation symbols I will use and what they mean:

2 ways active reading is different from passive reading:

1 word from today's passage I looked up or figured out from context:

REVIEW

Annotation Symbol Quick-Apply

Look at this sentence. Annotate it using your symbols from last class:

'The students who scored highest on the final exam were the ones who had annotated their textbooks most heavily — not the ones who had read the most pages.'

Explain what you marked and why.

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	6 min	8 min	13 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 3.2 — Writing Stamina & Clarity · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Stamina	<i>Etymology: Latin stamina (threads of life, staying power) — from stamen (the warp thread of cloth)</i>	The ability to sustain effort without quitting; in writing, the capacity to write productively for extended periods.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 3.2 · Reading: The Write Stuff: Building Stamina and Clarity in Your Writing

Source: Adapted from research on academic writing development and the writing process

■ Listen: reading_EN_3.2.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

In 9th grade and beyond, you will write more than you have ever written in your life. Research papers. In-class essays. Short-answer responses. Lab reports. Personal statements. And unlike the writing assignments you have done in middle school, high school writing — especially in Advanced Placement and college-level courses — is graded on complexity, evidence, and how precisely you use language. Writing, like running, requires stamina: the ability to keep going when your brain wants to stop.

The biggest mistake most student writers make is trying to write perfectly on the first try. When you edit as you draft — stopping to fix every sentence before moving to the next — you interrupt your thinking, lose your train of thought, and produce a fragmented draft that took twice as long as it should have. Professional writers have known for centuries that the first draft's only job is to exist. It does not need to be good. It needs to be done. You fix it in revision.

Clarity in writing comes from precision. Vague language — 'things,' 'stuff,' 'it was good,' 'bad' — is the enemy of clear writing. Precise writers choose specific nouns and strong verbs. Instead of 'The character felt bad,' they write 'The character felt betrayed.' Instead of 'The study showed interesting things,' they write 'The study revealed that sleep deprivation reduces working memory capacity by up to 40 percent.' Every word choice is a decision, and the best writers make those decisions deliberately.

Sentence structure also affects clarity. Short sentences create emphasis and punch. Longer sentences, when constructed carefully with subordinate clauses and specific modifiers, can carry complex ideas with precision and nuance. The best writers vary their sentence length intentionally, using short sentences after long ones to let the reader pause and absorb. They also know when to cut: if a sentence does not add new information or sharpen the argument, it should be deleted. Strong writing is not about using more words. It is about choosing the right ones.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What does the reading mean by 'writing stamina'? Why will it matter more in high school than in middle school?

2. What is the biggest mistake most student writers make, according to the reading? Why does this mistake hurt the final product?

3. Find ONE example of vague language in the reading's examples and rewrite it with precision. Then write your own example of a vague sentence and a precise revision.

4. The reading discusses sentence structure and variety. Find a sentence in the reading that is short and punchy, and one that is long and complex. Explain how each one works.

5. The reading says 'strong writing is not about using more words — it's about choosing the right ones.' Do you agree? Write 3-4 sentences responding to this idea using specific examples from your own writing experience.

"The Second Draft"

■ Listen: story_EN_3.2.m4a

Maya had written four drafts of the intro paragraph. Jordan had written zero drafts of anything. They were supposed to turn in a first draft the next day.

"How do you write four intros," Jordan said.

"The first three were bad."

"What was wrong with them?"

She pulled them out. He read the first one. It sounded fine to him. He said so.

"It starts with 'In today's world.' That's not allowed."

"By who?"

"By anyone who's serious."

He read the second one. *"This one's good."*

"It's too safe. I'm not actually saying anything."

The third one was shorter. Punchier. Jordan liked it.

"Why didn't you use this one?"

"I thought I could do better."

"Maya. That's a good intro."

"Fourth one is better."

He read the fourth one. It was good. But it had taken her two hours to get there, and she hadn't written any of the actual essay yet, and he didn't want to say that.

"I have nothing written," he said.

"I know."

"What do I do."

She thought about it. "Write a bad intro. On purpose. Worst possible first sentence. Just to start."

"That's not real advice."

"It's what I should have done. If I had a bad draft at the start, I could fix it. Instead I spent two hours on one paragraph."

Jordan wrote: Writing is hard and essays are bad.

It was terrible. He kept going.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Maya writes four intros and still hasn't written the essay. Jordan writes nothing. Who is struggling more — and why?

2. Maya tells Jordan to 'write a bad intro on purpose.' Why would starting badly be better than not starting at all?

3. What's the difference between editing as you write and drafting without stopping? Which is harder for you — and why?

4. Jordan's terrible first sentence is still a beginning. What does this story suggest about what it takes to build writing stamina?

Unit 3 · Lesson 3.2 — Writing Stamina & Clarity

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Define writing stamina and explain why it is a learnable skill.
- Apply a structured process (plan → draft → revise) to a short writing task.
- Use precise vocabulary and varied sentence structure to improve clarity.

The Plan-Draft-Revise Cycle

Strong writers don't just sit down and write perfectly the first time. They use a process. **PLAN:** spend 2–5 minutes before writing. Jot down your main idea, 2–3 supporting points, and any key evidence. **DRAFT:** write without stopping — don't edit as you go; just get your thinking down. **REVISE:** read your draft and ask, 'Is this clear? Is every sentence necessary? Did I use precise words?' In rigorous high school courses, you will be expected to write under time pressure (timed essays, in-class writes). Building writing stamina now means that pressure won't stop you.

Timed Write: Building Your Stamina

You have 12 minutes to respond to this prompt. Use the Plan-Draft-Revise process. Do NOT stop writing once you begin your draft. PROMPT: What is the most important skill a student needs to succeed in high school? Use specific evidence from your own experience or from what you have learned in this course to support your answer.

Time: 12 min · Plan (2 min): _____ **· Draft:**

Revision: Making It Clearer

Exchange your draft with a partner. Use the checklist below to give feedback. Then revise your own draft based on the feedback you receive.

- The main idea is clear in the first 2 sentences.
- Each paragraph has one main point.
- Specific examples or evidence are included.
- Vague words (thing, stuff, good, bad) have been replaced with precise ones.
- There are no run-on sentences or fragments.

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 3.2: Writing Stamina & Clarity

What is ONE thing you did in today's timed write that you are proud of? What is ONE thing you will work on next time? Be specific.

ANTICIPATION

How Do YOU Study?

Before you look at any notes — describe your exact study method for a big test:

Step 1: _____

Step 2: _____

Step 3: _____

Do you think it works? How would you know?

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	10 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 3.3 — Study Strategies & Spaced Practice · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Spaced Practice	<i>Etymology: Latin spatium (space, interval) + Latin practicare (to practice, perform)</i>	Spreading studying across multiple sessions over time, rather than cramming everything into one session.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 3.3 · Reading: Study Smarter, Not Harder: The Science of How We Actually Learn

Source: Adapted from research by Roediger & Butler (2011), Bjork (2015), and the Learning Scientists

■ Listen: reading_EN_3.3.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Most students study the way they feel comfortable, not the way the science says works best. Re-reading notes. Highlighting passages. Re-watching lecture videos. These strategies feel productive — your eyes are moving across material, you recognize it, you feel like you know it. But research by cognitive scientist Henry Roediger and others shows that recognition is not the same as retrieval. You can recognize something when you see it and still be completely unable to recall it on a test.

The most powerful study strategy — supported by decades of research — is retrieval practice: the act of pulling information out of your memory without looking at your notes. Flashcards are one form of retrieval practice. Practice problems are another. Writing everything you remember on a blank page before looking at your notes (called a 'brain dump') is another. Every time you successfully retrieve a piece of information, you strengthen the neural pathway that stores it. Every time you fail to retrieve it and then look it up, you learn it more durably than if you had just re-read it. Struggle is not a sign of failure — it is the engine of learning.

The second most powerful strategy is spaced practice. Instead of studying for three hours the night before an exam, you study for one hour three days before, 45 minutes two days before, and 30 minutes the night before. The total time is actually less, but the distributed spacing creates what psychologists call the 'spacing effect' — information studied in spaced intervals is remembered significantly better and for longer than information crammed into one session. This is because sleep between study sessions allows the brain to consolidate memories.

A third strategy — interleaving — means mixing different types of problems or topics within a single study session rather than blocking (doing all of one type first, then all of another). Research by Bjork and colleagues found that interleaving feels harder in the moment but produces dramatically better performance on tests. When your studying feels easy, you are probably not learning much. When it feels a little difficult — when you have to think to retrieve the answer — that difficulty is exactly what is building durable knowledge.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is retrieval practice and how is it different from re-reading your notes?

2. Explain the 'spacing effect' in your own words. Why does spacing study sessions improve learning?

3. What is interleaving? Give an example of how a student could use interleaving when studying for a math test.

4. The reading says 'struggle is not a sign of failure — it is the engine of learning.' What does this mean? How does it connect to the Growth Mindset ideas you may have heard before?

5. Design a study plan for your MOST challenging subject right now. Use at least two strategies from this reading (retrieval practice, spaced practice, or interleaving). Be specific about what you will do and when.

"The Night Before"

■ Listen: story_EN_3.3.m4a

It was the night before the unit test. In the group chat:

Jordan: how are you guys studying

Eli: rereading my notes rn. probably do that for like an hour

Maya: I did practice problems tuesday. then yesterday I covered my notes and tried to write everything from memory. tonight I'm doing it again but just the parts I got wrong

Jordan: tuesday?? you started tuesday?

Maya: test was announced tuesday

Jordan: i thought it was announced wednesday

Maya: it was announced tuesday jordan

Jordan: ok

Jordan: ok so how bad is rereading actually

A pause.

Eli: what do you mean how bad

Jordan: like if I reread is that doing nothing or is it something

Maya: it depends on if you're thinking while you read or just reading

Jordan: define thinking while reading

Maya: like stopping every section and asking yourself what the main point was. without looking.

Jordan tried it. He reread the first section of his notes. He looked away. He tried to say the main point out loud, to himself, in his room. He couldn't. He thought he could. He could not.

He went back. He reread. He looked away again. He got about half of it.

Maya: how's it going

Jordan: it's going. it's going terribly.

Maya: that means it's working

He stared at his phone. That didn't make any sense. He read another section. He looked away. He tried again.

He got a little more.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Why does Maya say 'that means it's working' when Jordan says the studying feels terrible? What does struggle during practice actually indicate?

2. Eli is rereading his notes. Maya says it 'depends on if you're thinking while you read.' What's the difference between those two kinds of rereading?

3. Jordan discovers he can't recall the section he just read. Most students would feel frustrated and stop. Why is that moment actually the most valuable part of studying?

4. How do you typically study the night before a test? After today's lesson, what would you change?

Unit 3 · Lesson 3.3 — Study Strategies & Spaced Practice

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Distinguish between effective and ineffective study strategies using research evidence.
- Apply spaced practice and retrieval practice to a real upcoming test or assignment.
- Build a personal study schedule using their planner.

What the Research Says

Decades of cognitive science research have identified a clear hierarchy of study strategies. At the bottom: re-reading notes and highlighting (low effectiveness). Near the top: RETRIEVAL PRACTICE (testing yourself — flashcards, practice problems, writing from memory) and SPACED PRACTICE (spreading study sessions over days and weeks). The spacing effect is one of the most replicated findings in all of psychology: you remember far more when you study in short, spaced sessions than in one long cram session — even if the total study time is the same. In AP and advanced courses at TRHS, the amount of material is too large to cram. Spacing and retrieval aren't just better — they're necessary.

Activity: Build a Study Plan

Identify ONE upcoming test or major assignment in any of your current classes. Use your planner and the template below to build a spaced study plan for it.

Subject / Assignment:

Due date / Test date:

Study Session 1 (date & what I will do):

Study Session 2 (date & what I will do):

Study Session 3 (date & what I will do):

How I will test myself (retrieval practice method):

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 3.3: Study Strategies & Spaced Practice

How different is this study approach from what you normally do? (1 = same as always, 5 = completely different). Explain the most important change you will make and when you will start.

1 Not at all	2	3 Somewhat	4	5 Absolutely
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REVIEW

Study Strategy Ranking

From last class: put these strategies in order from MOST effective (1) to LEAST effective (5) according to the research:

- ___ Re-reading
- ___ Highlighting
- ___ Retrieval practice
- ___ Spaced repetition
- ___ Interleaving

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	9 min	11 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 3.4 — Managing Long-Term Projects & Self-Advocacy · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Synthesis	<i>Etymology: Greek synthesis (putting together) — syn (together) + tithenai (to place)</i>	Combining multiple pieces of information or ideas to build a new, deeper understanding — going beyond summary.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 3.4 · Reading: Doing Hard Things: Self-Advocacy, Long-Term Projects, and Academic Resilience

Source: Adapted from research on academic self-advocacy and project management

■ Listen: reading_EN_3.4.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Every student, at some point in high school, will hit a wall. A project that feels overwhelming. A concept they cannot figure out. A grade that does not reflect the effort they put in. A class they registered for that is harder than they expected. How a student responds in that moment — whether they give up, ask for help, or find a strategy — is one of the strongest predictors of their long-term academic success.

Self-advocacy is the ability to understand your own needs and communicate them clearly to the people who can help. In an elementary school, a teacher often notices when students are struggling and steps in to help. In high school — and certainly in college — students who wait to be noticed often wait too long. Research consistently shows that students who ask for help early, when they first notice confusion, learn significantly more than students who either never ask or ask only in crisis.

Asking for help is a skill, and like all skills, it improves with practice. The most effective way to ask a teacher for help is to be specific. 'I don't understand the homework' gets a very different response than 'I was working on problem 7, and I understand how to set up the equation, but I got confused at the point where you have to factor. Can you show me that step?' The second version tells the teacher exactly where your thinking broke down. It also signals that you actually tried — which teachers notice and respect.

Long-term projects are where many students first discover they need better systems. The key to managing any large project is backward planning: starting at the deadline and mapping tasks backward through the calendar until you reach today. A student who receives a three-week research paper assignment on a Monday and immediately backward plans — 'I need to submit by Friday the 21st, so my draft should be done by Tuesday the 18th, my research by Friday the 14th, my outline by Wednesday the 12th, my topic by tomorrow' — will always outperform the student who starts on the Thursday before the Friday deadline. Backward planning makes the invisible visible: you can see exactly where you are and exactly what you need to do next.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is self-advocacy? Why does the reading say it matters more in high school than in elementary school?

2. Compare these two help-seeking statements: 'I don't get it' vs. 'I understand how to set up the equation but I got confused at the factoring step.' What makes the second one more effective?

3. What is backward planning and how does it work? Create a backward plan for a hypothetical project: 'A 10-slide presentation due in 2 weeks.'

4. The reading says 'how a student responds when they hit a wall is one of the strongest predictors of long-term academic success.' Do you agree? Why or why not?

5. Think about a time when you struggled academically and either asked for help or didn't. What happened? What would you do differently now, using ideas from this reading?

"The Ask"

■ Listen: story_EN_3.4.m4a

Eli had been failing the unit quietly for three weeks.

Not failing failing — more like a slow slide. A 72 that became a 68, a homework score that didn't get entered because he hadn't turned it in. He checked the grade portal when he was feeling brave, which was not often.

Priya found out by accident, when he left the portal open on the library computer and she sat down before she realized whose screen it was.

She didn't say anything for a moment.

"Is that your history grade?"

He closed the window. "Yeah."

"Eli."

"I know."

"Have you talked to Mr. Abara?"

"No."

"Why not?"

He didn't answer right away. The real reason was embarrassing: he liked Mr. Abara, and he didn't want Mr. Abara to think less of him. Asking for help felt like admitting he wasn't keeping up, and admitting he wasn't keeping up felt like giving up something he couldn't get back.

"It's complicated," he said.

"It's a conversation."

"It's more than that."

Priya thought about this. She'd had her own version of it — with math, in sixth grade, when she was new and didn't want to look slow in front of people who'd been in the district forever.

"I used to think asking for help meant I couldn't handle it," she said. "Now I think people who ask are just smarter about what they need."

Eli looked at the closed window. The grade was still there.

"What would you even say?" he asked.

"Hi, I'm behind and I want to get caught up. Is there a way to do that?"

"That's it?"

"That's it."

He thought about Mr. Abara's classroom. The door was usually open before school.

He hadn't gone in once.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Eli says his reason for not asking is 'complicated.' Priya reduces it to one sentence. Who is right — and what does Eli's hesitation actually come from?

2. Priya shares her own experience with not asking for help. Why does that moment matter? What does it do to the conversation?

3. What's the difference between being unable to do something and being unwilling to ask for help with it?

4. If you were Eli, what would make it easier to walk through Mr. Abara's door? What specific words would you use?

Unit 3 · Lesson 3.4 — Managing Long-Term Projects & Self-Advocacy

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Break a long-term project into a backward-planned sequence of steps.
- Demonstrate self-advocacy skills through role-play (asking a teacher for help).
- Apply synthesis skills by connecting learning from Units 1–3.

Backward Planning a Long-Term Project

When you receive a long-term assignment, high-performing students start at the END and work backward. Step 1: Write down the final deadline. Step 2: Identify all the tasks that must be done before the final product is ready. Step 3: Assign each task its own deadline, working backward from the final due date. Step 4: Enter each task in your planner. This makes a project that felt overwhelming feel manageable — because each day you know exactly what you need to do.

Activity: Backward Plan a Project

Use the timeline below to backward-plan either a real upcoming project or this scenario: 'You have 3 weeks to write a 5-page research paper on a historical event.'

Week	Tasks to Complete	My Mini-Deadline
Week 3		
Week 2		
Week 1		

Self-Advocacy: Asking for Help

One of the most important skills in rigorous courses is knowing when and how to ask for help. Research shows that students who ask questions and seek help learn more — but many students avoid asking out of embarrassment or not knowing how. With a partner, practice this script: 'Hi [Teacher's name], I was working on [assignment] and I'm having trouble with [specific part]. I've already tried [what I attempted]. Could you help me understand [specific question]?' Notice: be specific. Saying 'I don't get it' gets a different response than explaining exactly what you tried and where you got stuck.

Scenario: *You bombed a quiz and want to understand what went wrong.*

Your script:

Scenario: *You have a project due in 2 weeks and don't understand the requirements.*

Your script:

Scenario: *You missed class and need to catch up on notes.*

Your script:

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 3.4: Managing Long-Term Projects & Self-Advocacy

Look back at Units 1, 2, and 3. Choose ONE skill from EACH unit that you think will be most important for your success in 9th grade. Write a paragraph (5–7 sentences) explaining your three choices and how they connect to each other.

Unit 3: Academic Preparation for Rigorous Courses — POST-TEST

Directions: Revisit your pre-test responses. Rewrite your answer to Question 3 (how you study for a test) using at least three strategies from this unit. Then write a paragraph describing how your approach to reading or writing has changed as a result of this unit.

Unit 4

My 9th Grade Year Plan

In this unit you will use the Two Rivers Academic Planning Guide to build a realistic, personalized plan for your 9th grade year. You will draft a course schedule, map out your time outside of school, explore activities and athletics, and create a daily time management plan that reflects who you are and what you want to accomplish.

Unit Vocabulary

Prerequisite — A course or requirement that must be completed before a student can enroll in a more advanced course.

Credit — A unit of academic achievement; at TRHS, a semester-long course typically earns 0.5 credits, and a full-year course earns 1 credit.

GPA (Grade Point Average) — A number (on a 4.0 scale at TRHS) that represents your average grade across all courses. Weighted courses can earn up to 4.8.

Elective — A course that a student chooses based on personal interest; not required for graduation but counts toward total credits.

Unit 4: My 9th Grade Year Plan — PRE-TEST

Directions: Answer as completely as you can RIGHT NOW. This is NOT graded for correctness — it shows your starting point. Be honest!

1. Name THREE courses you know you will be required to take in 9th grade at TRHS.

2. What is a GPA and how is it calculated?

3. List any activities, clubs, or sports you are considering joining in high school.

4. How many hours per night do you currently spend on homework? How many do you think you will need in high school?

5. What does it mean to 'plan your time'? What strategies do you currently use?

LAUNCH

What Do You Actually Know About Graduation?

Without looking anything up — answer as specifically as you can:

1. How many total credits do you need to graduate from Two Rivers? ____
2. Name one course that is REQUIRED for every student: _____
3. What is the difference between required courses and electives?

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 4.1 — Reading the Academic Planning Guide · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Prerequisite	<i>Etymology: Latin prae (before) + requirere (to need, to seek)</i>	A course that must be completed before enrolling in a more advanced one — your entry ticket to the next level.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 4.1 · Reading: Reading the Map: Understanding Graduation Requirements and Course Pathways

Source: Adapted from the TRHS 2026-27 Academic Planning Guide and college readiness research

■ Listen: *reading_EN_4.1.m4a*

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

At Two Rivers High School, graduating is not just about showing up for four years. It requires earning 23 specific credits, including credits in Language Arts, Social Studies, Mathematics (through Algebra II at minimum), Science (Earth & Space Science, Biology, and Chemistry or Physics), Physical Education and Health, the Arts, Personal Finance, and Warrior Seminar. This sounds like a lot — because it is. But it is also carefully designed to give every student a broad foundation before they specialize.

The graduation plan is organized around 7 class periods per day. In 9th grade, students entering in the Class of 2029 or later will take: Language Arts 9 (or Advanced Language Arts 9), Human Geography & Ethnic Studies (or AP Human Geography), Math (wherever they are in the math sequence), Earth & Space Science (or AP Environmental Science), and Warrior Seminar. That accounts for 5 required courses. That leaves 2 slots per semester for student-choice electives — and those elective slots are where your 9th grade year becomes personal.

Before selecting electives, students must understand two important concepts. First, prerequisites: many courses can only be taken after completing an earlier course. You cannot take AP Biology before Biology, or Woodworking II before Woodworking I. This means 9th grade choices have real consequences for 10th grade options. If you want to take CADD in 10th grade, you need to start in 9th. If you want to pursue the music pathway, starting in 9th grade ensures you can reach the advanced ensembles before graduation.

Second, students must understand the difference between general, advanced, and honors pathways. Two Rivers offers most required courses at two or three levels. Language Arts 9 is the general track; Advanced Language Arts 9 is the enriched track; AP courses are college-level. Choosing a higher-level course is not just about difficulty — it is about being challenged in a way that prepares you for what comes next. Research consistently shows that students who take rigorous courses in high school are better prepared for college, even if their grades in those courses are not perfect.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What are the subject areas required for graduation from Two Rivers? List them all and note how many credits each requires.

2. In 9th grade (Class of 2029+), which courses are required? How many elective slots does a 9th grader have?

3. What is a prerequisite and why does it matter when you are planning your 9th grade schedule?

4. The reading says 'students who take rigorous courses in high school are better prepared for college, even if their grades are not perfect.' What does this imply about how you should choose your courses?

5. Using the Academic Planning Guide, list three electives you could realistically take in 9th grade that connect to your career interests from Unit 2. Check their prerequisites.

"Twenty-Two Credits"

■ Listen: story_EN_4.1.m4a

The counselor had them add up their graduation credits.

Maya had already done it. She'd done it in October, then again in November with updated course interest, then once more when she heard the requirements might change (they hadn't). She had a spreadsheet.

Jordan had not done it. He started now, using the chart in the planning guide. He added up the required credits. Then he added up the electives. Then he looked at the total.

"Twenty-two," he said.

"Credits," Maya confirmed, without looking up.

"Over four years."

"Yes."

"That's... not that many."

She looked up now. "What do you mean?"

"Like, per year that's like five or six courses. I take six now."

"You have to take specific ones though."

"Yeah but still. I thought it would be more."

Priya was counting quietly. "It's more specific than it looks. Four years of English. Three of math. You have to actually plan it or you run out of space."

"Run out of space for what?"

"Electives. If you keep taking required courses later than you should, you don't have room for the CAPS program or whatever you actually want."

Jordan looked at his chart. He hadn't thought about it as a space problem. He'd thought of it as a list of things to get through. But Priya was right — there was a sequence, and the sequence mattered, and if you didn't look at it now, you'd figure that out sophomore year when it was too late to undo.

Eli was staring at the prerequisite chain for the Transportation pathway. Five courses. He needed to start freshman year or the sequence wouldn't work.

"I needed to know this in seventh grade," he said quietly.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Eli says he needed to know this in seventh grade. Is that frustration fair — or is this exactly the right time to be planning? Explain your thinking.

2. Priya reframes the graduation requirements as a 'space problem.' How does that reframe change how you should think about course selection?

3. Jordan thought of graduation requirements as a list to get through. How is that different from seeing them as a pathway to something specific?

4. Looking at your own four-year plan: are there courses you want to take that have prerequisites you haven't met yet? What does that mean for 9th grade?

Unit 4 · Lesson 4.1 — Reading the Academic Planning Guide

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Locate and summarize graduation requirements for the Class of 2029 and beyond.
- Explain the difference between required courses, electives, and CAPS experiences.
- Identify which 9th grade courses are required and which are student-choice.

Graduation Requirements for Class of 2029 and Beyond

To graduate from Two Rivers, students must earn a minimum of 23 credits. Required areas include: Language Arts (4 credits), Social Studies (4 credits), Mathematics (3 credits — through Algebra II minimum), Science (3 credits — Earth & Space Science, Biology, plus Chemistry or Physics), Physical Education & Health (1.5 credits), Warrior Seminar (0.5 credits), Arts (1 credit), Personal Finance (0.5 credits), and Electives (5.5 credits). This means more than half of your credits are REQUIRED — but nearly a third are yours to choose.

Activity: Required vs. Choice — 9th Grade Edition

Based on the Warrior Graduation Plan (Class of 2029+) and the Academic Planning Guide, fill in the chart below for your 9th grade year.

Period	Semester 1	Semester 2
Period 1		
Period 2		
Period 3		
Period 4		
Period 5		
Period 6		
Period 7		

Use the graduation plan on pages 12-13 of the Academic Planning Guide to fill in required courses, then use elective slots for courses of your choice.

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 4.1: Reading the Academic Planning Guide

One thing I did NOT know about TRHS graduation requirements before today is...

A required 9th grade course I am looking forward to is _____ because...

A question I still have about building my schedule is...

REVIEW

Graduation Requirement Recall

From last class — fill in from memory:

Required English credits (9-12): ____ Required math: ____ Required science: ____

Open elective credits available: ____

Warrior Seminar is worth ____ credits and is taken in grade ____

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	9 min	6 min	7 min	15 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 4.2 — My Mock 9th Grade Schedule · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Elective	<i>Etymology: Latin electus (chosen, selected) — from eligere (to choose, to pick out)</i>	A course chosen by the student that goes beyond required coursework — your opportunity to follow your interests.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 4.2 · Reading: Your Schedule, Your Foundation: Building a 9th Grade Course Plan

Source: Adapted from TRHS 2026-27 Academic Planning Guide and school counselor guidance

■ Listen: reading_EN_4.2.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Warrior Seminar is not just another class — it is Two Rivers' investment in your transition. Every 9th grader takes it (unless they are in AVID or AP Human Geography Enrichment), and its purpose is to give you the time, structure, and support to learn how to be a high school student. In Warrior Seminar, you will develop time management and note-taking skills, meet with professional mentors four times during the year, hear from guest speakers in various career fields, and begin building your post-secondary portfolio. Everything you are learning in Warrior Prep connects directly to what you will do in Warrior Seminar — this course is preparing you for that one.

Building your 9th grade schedule is one of the most consequential decisions you will make this year. The Academic Planning Guide lays out the full picture of what is available — but it is up to you to read it carefully, ask questions, and make intentional choices. A few guiding principles from students who have done this well: Do not take all your most challenging courses in the same semester. Balance academic rigor with courses you genuinely enjoy. Choose at least one elective that connects to a career interest, even if you are not sure yet. And never skip Warrior Seminar unless you have a compelling reason and counselor approval.

Your math placement deserves special attention. Math is the course where prerequisite chains are longest and most consequential. Students on the 'double acceleration' path may be taking high school math courses already in 8th grade (like Pre-AP Geometry or Algebra II). Students on the standard path enter 9th grade in Geometry or Algebra II depending on their 8th grade math. Students on the single acceleration path may enter in Pre-AP Geometry. Know where you are in this sequence — it determines how far you can go in math by graduation, and whether options like AP Calculus or AP Statistics will be available to you.

Finally, remember that your schedule is registered in December of 8th grade and is considered final at Two Rivers. Changes are not accommodated after submission. This is not bureaucratic inflexibility — it is because enrollment numbers, class sizes, and teacher assignments are all determined by student registrations. The pressure this creates is real, which is exactly why taking this planning work seriously right now matters.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is Warrior Seminar and what does it include? How does it connect to Warrior Prep?

2. List the three 'guiding principles' the reading offers for building a 9th grade schedule. Do you agree with all three? Are there any you would add?

3. Why does the reading say math placement 'deserves special attention'? Where are you currently in the math sequence?

4. Why are 9th grade course registrations considered final at Two Rivers? What does this tell you about how seriously you should take this planning?

5. Using the Academic Planning Guide and your reading notes, create a draft of your 7-period 9th grade schedule. For each elective slot, write a one-sentence rationale.

"Period Seven"

■ Listen: story_EN_4.2.m4a

Jordan's mock schedule had a problem. He'd filled in periods one through six just fine — he had requirements to take and he took them. But period seven was a blank, and he'd been staring at it for ten minutes.

"What do you have for seven?" he asked Maya.

"Digital Media Design."

"Is that good?"

"I looked up the syllabus. You design actual things. Print layouts, websites, graphics. And it connects to the ACI career field."

Jordan looked at the elective list. "There's a cooking class."

"Culinary Arts," Maya said. "That connects to the Food and Natural Resources field, actually."

"I just want to cook."

"That's allowed."

He wrote it in. Then looked at it. Then erased it.

"What?" Maya said.

"It sounds like I'm not taking school seriously."

"Why would culinary arts be less serious than digital media design?"

He thought about it. It wasn't a clear answer. It was more like a feeling — that real courses were hard and academic-sounding, and fun courses were ones you slid into when you didn't care. But the planning guide had Culinary Arts listed with a career field and a credit weight and a pathway description.

"What if I'm wasting the spot?" he said.

"On something you're actually interested in?"

"On something that doesn't... matter."

Maya put her pencil down. "Jordan. Why does it not matter that you want to learn how to cook?"

He didn't have a good answer. He looked at period seven. Still blank.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Jordan erases his choice because it 'sounds like he's not taking school seriously.' Where does that belief come from — and is it accurate?

2. Maya asks why cooking 'doesn't matter.' How would you answer that question honestly?

3. What's the difference between choosing an elective you enjoy and choosing one that looks impressive? Does that difference matter for 9th grade?

4. If period seven were yours to fill in today, what would you choose — and why? Would you feel confident saying that choice out loud?

Unit 4 · Lesson 4.2 — My Mock 9th Grade Schedule

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Create a complete, realistic mock 9th grade course schedule using the Academic Planning Guide.
- Select elective courses that align with personal interests and/or career pathway goals.
- Verify that their schedule meets all 9th grade requirements.

Warrior Seminar — Your Built-In Support

Every 9th grader takes Warrior Seminar (unless in AVID or AP Human Geo Enrichment). This course is designed specifically to help you transition to high school — it covers time management, note-taking strategies, career awareness, and builds your post-secondary portfolio. You'll meet with a professional mentor four times during the year. This course is DIRECTLY connected to Warrior Prep — everything you learn here will help you succeed there.

Build Your Mock Schedule

Use the Academic Planning Guide to build your complete 9th grade mock schedule below. Fill in ALL 7 periods for both semesters. Be sure to: include all required courses, choose electives that connect to your career interests from Unit 2, check prerequisites, and verify you are on the right math track.

Period	Semester 1 Course	Semester 2 Course
Period 1		
Period 2		
Period 3		
Period 4		
Period 5		
Period 6		
Period 7		

Reflection: Which elective connects most to your Unit 2 career pathway? Explain:

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 4.2: My Mock 9th Grade Schedule

Look at your completed mock schedule. Which course are you most excited about and why? Which course concerns you most and why? What can you do NOW to prepare for that course?

ANTICIPATION

Activity Assumption Check

Agree, Disagree, or It Depends — write a reason for each:

1. 'Students who do extracurriculars have lower GPAs because they have less study time.'

A / D / ID: Reason: _____

2. 'It's better to try one activity deeply than three activities lightly.'

A / D / ID: Reason: _____

3. 'You should decide your activities before 9th grade starts.'

A / D / ID: Reason: _____

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 4.3 — Activities, Clubs & Sports at TRHS · Cornell Notes

Name: _____ Date: _____

Date: _____ Period: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Credit	<i>Etymology: Latin creditum (something entrusted) — from credere (to believe, trust)</i>	In school, a unit of earned academic achievement. In life, earned trust and recognition for your work and involvement.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 4.3 · Reading: More Than a Club: The Case for Getting Involved in High School

Source: Adapted from research on extracurricular involvement and adolescent development

■ Listen: reading_EN_4.3.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Here is a finding that consistently surprises students: research shows that high school students who participate in extracurricular activities have higher GPAs, better attendance, lower dropout rates, and stronger social-emotional well-being than students who do not. This is not because athletes or musicians are smarter than other students. It is because structured activities create accountability, belonging, and purpose — three conditions that are powerful drivers of academic motivation.

Belonging is especially important during the transition to high school. The 9th grade year is consistently identified by researchers as the most pivotal in a student's educational trajectory. Students who feel connected to their school in 9th grade — who have relationships with peers and adults outside of a single classroom — are significantly more likely to graduate and go on to post-secondary education. Extracurricular activities are the most reliable pathway to that connection.

Two Rivers offers an extraordinary range of options: more than 20 clubs, a full spectrum of seasonal sports for boys and girls, performance groups in music and theater, service organizations like Key Club and LINK Crew, academic competitions like Speech and Science Olympiad, and student governance through Student Council. The variety matters: there is something here for every student, whether your strength is leadership, creativity, competition, service, or simply finding people who share your interests.

The students who struggle most with extracurricular involvement usually cite one of two concerns: time and fear. Time is a real challenge — athletics especially can demand 10-15 hours per week during a season. But research actually shows that students involved in activities manage their time better, not worse — the constraint of a packed schedule forces the discipline that students without those constraints often lack. Fear of trying something new is real too. But the research is clear: students who join at least one new activity in 9th grade consistently report that it was one of the best decisions they made in high school.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What does the research say about the relationship between extracurricular involvement and academic performance? Why does this relationship exist?

2. Why is belonging especially important during the 9th grade year, according to the reading?

3. The reading mentions students cite 'time' and 'fear' as barriers to involvement. How does the reading respond to each concern?

4. Two Rivers offers more than 20 clubs and many sports and activities. Which THREE interest you most? For each, explain why and what you would hope to get out of it.

5. The reading says 'students who join at least one new activity in 9th grade consistently report it was one of the best decisions they made in high school.' What is ONE activity you have never tried before that you are willing to commit to trying? What makes it a stretch for you?

"The Sign-Up"

■ Listen: story_EN_4.3.m4a

The activities fair was in the gym. Tables for every club, sport, and program.

Eli went straight to the lacrosse table. He'd played since fifth grade. That wasn't a decision; it was just what he did.

Jordan went to the photography club table because his friend was going, then to the robotics table because the poster was cool, then to get a water from the concession stand. He held three sign-up sheets and hadn't committed to any of them.

Priya stood near the entrance for four minutes without moving.

There was a Literary Magazine table on the left. She wrote. Not for anyone, not for any class — she just wrote, in notebooks she kept in her desk drawer at home. She'd never told anyone.

She walked toward it. Stopped. Walked toward the Computer Science club table instead — more practical, she told herself, better for applications.

Eli found her at the CS table. "You doing CS club?"

"Maybe."

"Cool." He paused. "You looked at the other one though. The writing one."

"I write sometimes."

"Like, for fun?"

She didn't answer. For fun was hard to say out loud, like it was a confession.

"Priya," Eli said, "you should do the thing you actually want to do."

"CS is more useful."

"Useful for what?"

She looked at the Literary Magazine table. A student was talking about a piece they'd had published in a regional anthology. Priya had never told anyone she wanted to do something like that.

She picked up the sign-up sheet.

She put it back down.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Priya puts the sign-up sheet back down. What is she afraid of — and is that fear logical?

2. Eli chooses lacrosse without thinking because it's familiar. Is that a good enough reason? What are the benefits and costs of choosing what's comfortable?

3. Jordan holds three sign-up sheets without committing. What does he need to make an actual choice — and what's stopping him?

4. Is there an activity or interest you've kept private the way Priya keeps her writing private? What would it take to put it on a sign-up sheet?

Unit 4 · Lesson 4.3 — Activities, Clubs & Sports at TRHS

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Identify at least 5 activities, clubs, or sports available at TRHS.
- Evaluate how involvement in extracurriculars connects to skills, relationships, and college readiness.
- Create a personal list of activities they want to try in 9th grade.

Why Get Involved?

Research consistently shows that students who are involved in extracurricular activities have higher GPAs, better attendance, and stronger social connections than students who are not. Activities build skills you can't get in a classroom: leadership, teamwork, time management under pressure, commitment, and resilience. They also appear on your college applications and résumé. Perhaps most importantly, finding something you love at TRHS makes school a place you WANT to be.

TRHS Activities, Clubs & Sports Directory

Below is a partial list of activities available at Two Rivers. Circle anything that interests you. Put a star next to your top 3.

Clubs

- | | | |
|----------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------|
| ■ Art Club | ■ Asian & Pacific Islander Club | ■ Bass Fishing |
| ■ Bowling | ■ Digital Wellbeing | ■ Dungeons & Dragons |
| ■ GISA | ■ Jewish Student Union | ■ Library Club |
| ■ LiveGreen | ■ Model United Nations | ■ Muslim Student Association |
| ■ Pickleball | ■ Ping Pong | ■ Pokemon |
| ■ Pom Squad | ■ Sports Analytics | ■ Trap Shooting |
| ■ Unified Club | ■ Women in STEM | |

Activities

- | | | |
|-----------------|--------------------|----------------|
| ■ Debate | ■ Fall Play | ■ Jazz Band |
| ■ Marching Band | ■ Musical | ■ One Act Play |
| ■ Robotics | ■ Science Olympiad | ■ Speech |
| ■ Vocal Jazz | ■ Winterguard | ■ Cheer |

Service Groups

- | | | |
|--------------------------|-------------------|-----------------|
| ■ ALMAS | ■ Key Club | ■ LINK Crew |
| ■ National Honor Society | ■ Student Council | ■ Tech Warriors |

Fall Sports

- | | | |
|------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------|
| ■ Cross Country (Boys) | ■ Cross Country (Girls) | ■ Football |
| ■ Soccer (Boys) | ■ Soccer (Girls) | ■ Swimming & Diving (Girls) |
| ■ Tennis (Girls) | ■ Volleyball | |

Winter Sports

- | | | |
|------------------------|-------------------------|----------------------------|
| ■ Basketball (Boys) | ■ Basketball (Girls) | ■ Dance |
| ■ Gymnastics | ■ Hockey (Boys) | ■ Hockey (Girls) |
| ■ Nordic Skiing (Boys) | ■ Nordic Skiing (Girls) | ■ Swimming & Diving (Boys) |
| ■ Wrestling | | |

Spring Sports

■ Baseball

■ Lacrosse (Boys)

■ Softball

■ Track & Field (Girls)

■ Golf (Boys)

■ Lacrosse (Girls)

■ Tennis (Boys)

■ Golf (Girls)

■ Soccer (Fall)

■ Track & Field (Boys)

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 4.3: Activities, Clubs & Sports at TRHS

My top 3 activities/clubs/sports I want to try in 9th grade:

One reason I chose each one:

One concern I have about balancing activities with schoolwork:

One strategy I will use to manage that balance:

REVIEW

Rapid-Fire: My 9th Grade Plan So Far

Quick-write in 2 minutes — answer all three:

1. Name TWO courses you've decided to take in 9th grade:

2. Name ONE activity you circled in the activities checklist: _____

3. One word that describes how you feel about starting 9th grade:

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	9 min	6 min	8 min	14 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 4.4 · Reading: The Math of Your Day: Time, Sleep, and the Reality of 9th Grade

Source: Adapted from research on adolescent time management and sleep science

■ Listen: reading_EN_4.4.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

A 9th grader's school day at Two Rivers runs from 8:25 AM to 3:05 PM — 6 hours and 40 minutes. That sounds like a lot, but once the day is over, the work is often just beginning. Two Rivers' official homework policy states that students should expect to spend at least 1.5 hours on homework per night in 9th grade, with advanced and AP courses requiring more. Add sports or activities (which can run 2-3 hours on practice days), dinner, a commute, and family time — and a 9th grader's evening can fill up very quickly.

Sleep is where many students unknowingly undermine their academic performance. The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends 8-10 hours of sleep per night for adolescents. Research from Harvard Medical School shows that sleep deprivation impairs working memory, reduces the ability to learn new information, and significantly increases emotional reactivity — which makes stress feel worse and coping feel harder. Students who sleep fewer than 7 hours perform, on average, like students who have been awake for 24 hours straight. No amount of studying compensates for chronic sleep loss.

The students who manage their time most effectively in high school share one key habit: they protect their study time first, then schedule everything else around it. This sounds simple, but it requires a shift in how you think about your day. Instead of asking 'when do I have time for homework?' at the end of the day — when you are tired and the evening is almost gone — they decide in advance: 'Homework happens from 4:30-6:30 every school day, no exceptions.' This kind of time blocking turns an intention into a structure.

Your daily schedule is not just about getting things done. It is also about sustainability. A 9th grade year that burns you out by November — because you overscheduled yourself, underslept, and never gave yourself time to breathe — does not build the habits you need for a successful four years. Building a realistic schedule now, while you have the chance to think carefully, is one of the most valuable things you can do to set yourself up for success.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. Using the information in the reading, calculate how many hours a 9th grader with one sport has available for homework, family time, and personal time on a practice day. Show your math.

2. What does research say about the effects of sleep deprivation on learning? List at least three specific effects from the reading.

3. What time management habit do the most effective students share, according to the reading? How is this different from how most students manage their time?

4. The reading warns against 'a 9th grade year that burns you out by November.' What are the signs of over-scheduling? How do you know if your schedule is sustainable?

5. Create a realistic time map for a typical school day in 9th grade. Include: wake time, school, activities/sports (if any), homework time, dinner, family/personal time, and sleep. Is your schedule sustainable? What would you change?

"The Map"

■ Listen: story_EN_4.4.m4a

The assignment was to map out a realistic weekday in 9th grade — hour by hour.

Eli did the math honestly. Practice ended at 5:30. Dinner was around 6:30 if his mom cooked, 7:00 if she didn't. He worked at his uncle's shop on Tuesdays and Thursdays until 7:00. He needed eight hours of sleep to not feel like the inside of a locker.

He counted backward from his 6:30 AM alarm. He needed to be in bed by 10:30 PM at the latest.

Between 7:00 PM and 10:30 PM, he had three and a half hours.

Practice. Dinner. Homework. Shop two nights a week.

He stared at it.

"What's wrong," Maya said.

"I don't have enough time."

She looked at his time map. She did not immediately tell him he was wrong.

"What's non-negotiable?" she asked.

"Practice. The job. Sleep."

"How many credits are you taking?"

"Seven."

"How much homework per class?"

"Depends. History's a lot. Science sometimes."

"Have you ever actually tracked how long homework takes you?"

He had not. He guessed.

"You might be overestimating," she said. "Or you might actually be right. But you don't know yet."

"And if I'm right?"

She was quiet for a moment. "Then something has to change. And it's better to figure that out now than in October when you're already behind."

He looked at the map. The three and a half hours sat there. Honest and exact and possibly not enough.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Eli does the math honestly and doesn't like the result. Is that better or worse than not doing the math at all? Explain.

2. Maya asks 'what's non-negotiable?' Why is that question important — what does it force you to identify?

3. She also asks if Eli has ever tracked how long homework actually takes him. Most students haven't. Why does guessing lead to bad time planning?

4. Map your own honest weekday. What's non-negotiable? What's left over? Does the math work?

Unit 4 · Lesson 4.4 — My Daily Time Map

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Create a realistic daily schedule that accounts for school, homework, activities, and personal time.
- Identify and protect dedicated study time in their 9th grade schedule.
- Combine their mock course schedule, activity list, and time map into a coherent 9th Grade Year Plan.

The Math of Your Day

School day: 8:25 AM–3:05 PM = 6 hours 40 minutes. Sleep: TRHS recommends 8–9 hours (research shows teens need at least 8). That's 16–17 hours accounted for. You have 7–8 hours left for: homework (TRHS expects at least 1.5 hours/night for 9th grade), activities and sports (typically 2–3 hours on practice days), eating and commute, family time, and yes — screen time and downtime. When you map it out, the math is tight. High performers protect their homework time first, then schedule everything else around it.

Build Your Daily Time Map

Fill in a realistic schedule for a typical school day and a typical activity/sport day in 9th grade. Include wake-up time, school, activities, homework, meals, and bedtime.

Time	School Day	Activity/Sport Day
6:00 AM		
7:00 AM		
8:00 AM		
9:00 AM		
10:00 AM		
11:00 AM		
12:00 PM		
1:00 PM		
2:00 PM		
3:00 PM		
4:00 PM		
5:00 PM		
6:00 PM		
7:00 PM		
8:00 PM		
9:00 PM		
10:00 PM		
11:00 PM		

My 9th Grade Year Plan — Putting It All Together

You now have all the pieces of your 9th Grade Year Plan. Complete the summary below, referencing your work from Lessons 4.1–4.4.

My 9th grade courses (list all 7 periods):

My top 3 extracurricular activities:

My daily homework time (time and location):

My #1 academic goal for 9th grade:

One thing I am most excited about:

One thing I am most nervous about, and my plan for it:

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 4.4: My Daily Time Map

Imagine it is the end of your 9th grade year and it went exactly as you hoped. Write 5–7 sentences describing what that year looked like: your grades, your activities, how you managed your time, and how you felt. Be specific — use course names, activity names, and real details from your plan.

Directions: Attach or summarize your completed 9th Grade Mock Schedule from Lesson 4.2. Then write a paragraph (5–7 sentences) describing how you plan to balance your academic work, extracurricular activities, and personal time during your 9th grade year. Use specific times, course names, and activity names.

Unit 5

Transition to High School

In this final unit you will take everything you have learned and connect it directly to the experience of being a new student at Two Rivers High School. You will understand how grades and credits work, explore how to get involved, finalize your course selections, and hear directly from current TRHS students who have been in your shoes.

Unit Vocabulary

Weighted Grade — A grade that counts for more than a standard grade on the GPA scale, awarded for AP, CIS, and college-credit courses at TRHS (up to 4.8 instead of 4.0).

Transcript — Your official academic record — a document listing all your courses, grades, and credits earned in high school.

BARR (Building Assets, Reducing Risks) — A program at TRHS where 9th graders are placed on teams of 3-4 teachers who communicate regularly to support student success.

Concurrent Enrollment (CE) — Taking a high school course that also earns college credit, taught by a college-approved high school teacher.

Unit 5: Transition to High School — PRE-TEST

Directions: Answer as completely as you can RIGHT NOW. This is NOT graded for correctness — it shows your starting point. Be honest!

1. How is a high school GPA different from a middle school grade? What do you already know?

2. What questions do you have about high school grades, credits, or graduation?

3. What is ONE thing that makes you excited about starting high school?

4. What is ONE thing that makes you nervous about starting high school?

5. What advice do you wish someone had given you before starting middle school?

LAUNCH

Grade vs. GPA — What's the Difference?

Without any help — explain the difference between a grade and a GPA:

If a student gets a B in every class for one semester, what is their GPA? My best guess: ____

Explain your reasoning:

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	8 min	12 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 5.1 — Grades, Credits & GPA at TRHS · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Weighted Grade	<i>Etymology: Old English gewiht (weight, heaviness) + Latin gradus (step, rank)</i>	A grade that earns more GPA points, rewarding students who take advanced courses like AP and CIS.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 5.1 · Reading: Your Grade, Your GPA, Your Transcript: How Academic Performance Works at TRHS

Source: Adapted from the TRHS 2026-27 Academic Planning Guide

■ Listen: [reading_EN_5.1.m4a](#)

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

In middle school, grades matter — but in high school, they become part of a permanent record called your transcript. Your transcript follows you everywhere: to college applications, scholarship applications, and sometimes job applications. It shows every course you took, the grade you earned, the number of credits, and whether the course was standard, advanced, or AP. You cannot erase entries on your transcript, which means every semester counts from day one.

At Two Rivers, grades are recorded on a 4.0 scale for standard courses. An A earns 4.0 GPA points, a B earns 3.0, a C earns 2.0, a D earns 1.0, and an F earns 0.0. For AP, CIS (College in the Schools), and other college-credit courses, grades are weighted — meaning they can earn up to 4.8 GPA points for an A. This weighted system rewards students who challenge themselves. A student with a 3.5 GPA in all advanced courses is making a stronger academic statement than a student with a 3.8 GPA in all standard courses — college admissions officers understand this distinction.

The school year is divided into four quarters, with two quarters making one semester. A semester course earns 0.5 credits; a full-year course earns 1.0 credit. You need 23 credits to graduate. Failing a required course means you must retake it — which is possible but costly in time and scheduling flexibility. Two Rivers offers credit recovery sessions after school and in summer, but prevention is far better than recovery. The most effective strategy is to take your grade seriously from the first assignment in September.

One powerful tool students underuse is Infinite Campus, the district's grade and attendance portal. You and your parents can access it anytime to see your current grades, missing assignments, and attendance. Research on student success consistently shows that students who monitor their own grades regularly — rather than waiting for report cards — catch problems earlier and recover faster. If your grade in any class dips below where you want it to be, the time to act is the moment you notice it, not the week before finals.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is a transcript and why does it matter? List at least three situations where your transcript could be used.

2. Explain the difference between a standard GPA and a weighted GPA at Two Rivers. Give a specific example of how they are calculated differently.

3. How many credits does a semester course earn? A full-year course? How many credits total are required to graduate?

4. What is Infinite Campus and how does the reading say effective students use it? Do you currently use a similar tool to track your grades?

5. If a student receives a 78% (C+) at the quarter mark in their first AP course, what should they do? Write a specific action plan using information from this reading and from Unit 1 (executive functioning) and Unit 3 (self-advocacy).

"The Portal"

■ Listen: story_EN_5.1.m4a

Infinite Campus had been loaded on Jordan's phone since September. He had never opened it.

This was not an oversight. He'd made a decision, in the vague and unspoken way that most decisions happen: if he didn't look, the numbers couldn't surprise him. He knew roughly how he was doing. Roughly was fine.

Maya checked hers every Sunday and Wednesday. She had a system. Anything below a B+ got a plan.

Eli checked his on the first of every month. He told himself that was enough. It was not.

In Warrior Prep, the teacher had them log in. Jordan opened it in class for the first time.

He had a 74 in history. He'd thought it was maybe a 78. He had a missing assignment in science. He hadn't known about the missing assignment. He had a B- in English, which was fine, but there was a comment from his teacher: Jordan is capable of more specific analysis.

He read it three times.

"What," Maya said.

He showed her the comment.

She read it. "That's actually a compliment."

"How."

"She said 'capable.' She thinks you can. She's not saying you're bad at it."

He looked at it again. He'd read it as criticism. He hadn't read the word capable at all.

"The missing assignment," he said.

"Email her tonight."

"Can I even turn it in?"

"You won't know until you ask."

He put his phone down. He had been avoiding this for three months. In six minutes it had produced one comment that was actually encouraging, one problem he could maybe fix, and one grade that was lower than he'd assumed.

He wasn't sure how he felt about knowing.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Jordan has been deliberately not checking his grades. Is that a strategy — or avoidance? What's the difference?

2. Maya reads the teacher's comment as a compliment. Jordan reads it as criticism. What changes when you learn to read feedback differently?

3. Eli checks his grades monthly and thinks that's enough. Is it? What is the right frequency — and what should you do when you look?

4. After today's lesson, what would a weekly grade-check habit actually look like for you? What would you do with the information?

Unit 5 · Lesson 5.1 — Grades, Credits & GPA at TRHS

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Explain how credits, GPA, and weighted grades work at TRHS.
- Calculate a sample GPA using the TRHS grading scale.
- Identify the academic habits that protect and grow a strong GPA.

How Grades Work at TRHS

TRHS uses a 4.0 GPA scale for standard courses and a 4.8 scale for AP, CIS (College in the Schools), and college-credit courses. The school year has four quarters; your semester grade (the grade that appears on your transcript) is calculated from two quarters. A semester course earns 0.5 credits; a full-year course earns 1.0 credit. You need 23 total credits to graduate. Dropping a course after week 10 results in an F for that semester — so choose carefully and stay in courses you've started.

GPA Practice

Using the grading scale from the Academic Planning Guide, calculate the GPA for the sample student below. Then answer: What grade in which course would have the biggest positive impact on this GPA?

Course	Grade	Credits	GPA Points	Weighted Points
Language Arts 9	B+	1.0		
Human Geography & Ethnic Studies	A-	1.0		
Geometry	B	1.0		
Earth & Space Science	B-	1.0		
Warrior Seminar	A	0.5		
Woodworking I	A	0.5		
Intro to Organized Sports	B+	0.5		
		TOTAL →		

Habits That Protect Your GPA

Review the list below. Check the habits you already have. Circle the ones you want to build.

- I turn in all assignments on time.
- I use a planner to track due dates.
- I check my grades in Infinite Campus at least once a week.
- I ask for help before I fall too far behind.
- I use Warrior Time (Wednesday) to catch up or get ahead.
- I study over multiple days, not just the night before.
- I communicate with my teacher if I need an extension.
- I read feedback on returned work and apply it next time.

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 5.1: Grades, Credits & GPA at TRHS

If your goal is a 3.5 GPA in 9th grade, what does that mean in real terms (what grades do you need)? What is the single most important habit you will commit to in order to reach that goal?

REVIEW

GPA Impact Scenario

A student gets straight B's (3.0) in semester 1. In semester 2, they get one A and the rest B's. By how much does their GPA change? Show your work:

Then: what ONE habit change would have the biggest effect on a student's GPA?

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	10 min	7 min	10 min	10 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 5.2 — Getting Involved at TRHS · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: BARR (Building Assets, Reducing Risks)	<i>Etymology: Acronym for Building Assets, Reducing Risks — a model of structured team support for 9th graders</i>	A TRHS program that places every 9th grader on a small team of teachers who regularly communicate to support their success.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 5.2 · Reading: 9th Grade Is Different: BARR, Belonging, and the Warrior Way

Source: Adapted from research by the BARR Center and TRHS transition resources

■ Listen: [reading_EN_5.2.m4a](#)

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

Something unusual happens in 9th grade. Research on educational trajectories — the long-term patterns of student success — consistently identifies the 9th grade year as the single most predictive year in a student's K-12 career. Students who fail two or more courses in 9th grade have significantly lower graduation rates, regardless of how they performed in middle school.

Conversely, students who finish 9th grade on track — passing their courses, earning their credits, staying connected to school — go on to graduate and pursue post-secondary education at dramatically higher rates.

Two Rivers takes this research seriously, which is why every 9th grader is placed into the BARR model: Building Assets, Reducing Risks. In BARR, you are not just assigned to teachers — you are placed on a team. Your BARR team consists of 3-4 teachers who all share you and your classmates across their different courses. These teachers meet regularly to discuss student progress. They share information about grades, attendance, and social-emotional wellbeing. If you are struggling in two subjects at once, your BARR team will know — and they will reach out, not wait for you to come to them.

Your BARR teacher is a specific person on your team who serves as your primary contact and the contact for your family. They are the person who notices when something is off — when your attendance slides, when your grades dip, when you seem stressed or disconnected. Think of your BARR teacher as a built-in ally: someone who is not just in charge of teaching you a subject, but also invested in how you are doing as a whole person. Research on the BARR model, which began in Minnesota, shows significant improvements in 9th grade course passage rates and significant reductions in chronic absenteeism at schools that implement it well.

But BARR is not a safety net that catches you without your effort. It is a support structure that amplifies the effort you bring. Students who show up, engage, and reach out when they are struggling benefit enormously from the BARR system. Students who disengage, skip class, or hide their struggles miss most of its benefit. The single most important thing you can do in 9th grade is be present — physically in class, mentally engaged, and willing to communicate when things get hard.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. Why does research identify 9th grade as the most important year in a student's K-12 career? What are the consequences of failing courses in 9th grade?

2. What is BARR and how does it work at Two Rivers? How is it different from a regular school structure?

3. What is the role of a BARR teacher? How is it different from a regular classroom teacher?

4. The reading says BARR 'amplifies the effort you bring.' What does this mean? What must YOU do to benefit from BARR?

5. Based on the reading, list THREE specific behaviors you commit to in 9th grade that will help you take full advantage of the BARR structure. Explain why each one matters.

"The Team"

■ Listen: story_EN_5.2.m4a

The teacher explained BARR: a team of teachers who share the same 9th graders and actually talk about how they're doing.

Priya raised her hand. "Like, they share information about specific students?"

"Yes. If you're struggling in one class, your whole team might know."

Priya put her hand down. She thought about this. All her teachers knowing, at once, that she was struggling at something felt like standing under a spotlight she hadn't agreed to stand under.

After class, she told Maya.

"I think it sounds good," Maya said.

"You don't think it's weird that they all talk about you?"

"They already do. Every school. But in BARR it's organized, so it actually helps."

"What if you don't want the help?"

Maya looked at her. "When did you not want help?"

"It's different when people are watching."

"They're not watching to judge you. They're watching because they're supposed to."

Priya thought about sixth grade. She'd been new. She'd been quiet. No one had noticed she was lost in math for almost two months. By the time a teacher figured it out, she was far enough behind that it had taken the whole second semester to recover.

"Maybe if someone had been paying attention in sixth grade," she said slowly, "it would have been faster."

"Yeah," Maya said.

Priya looked at the handout about BARR. A team of teachers who share information and check in. A structure designed to notice before things get bad.

It still felt strange. But strange and bad were different things.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Priya is uncomfortable with BARR because it means teachers share information about her. Is that discomfort reasonable — or is something else going on?

2. Maya says 'they already do' — all schools share information about students. How does organizing that process change it?

3. Priya's sixth-grade experience shows what happens when no one is paying attention. How does that reframe her discomfort with BARR?

4. Would you rather have a team of teachers watching out for you — or teachers who each see only their own class? What are the real trade-offs?

Unit 5 · Lesson 5.2 — Getting Involved at TRHS

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Explain the connection between extracurricular involvement and academic and social well-being.
- Develop a personal strategy for trying new activities while maintaining academic balance.
- Identify at least one activity, one club/service group, and one sport they plan to explore.

The BARR Advantage

One of the best things about starting at TRHS is BARR. As a 9th grader, you will be assigned to a team of 3-4 teachers who have ALL of your classmates in at least one class. These teachers meet regularly to talk about how their students are doing — academically, socially, emotionally. If you're struggling, your BARR teacher will notice and reach out. If you're thriving, they'll know that too. You are NOT going to fall through the cracks at TRHS — the structure won't let you, as long as you show up.

The 'Try One Thing' Challenge

Research on high school students shows that students who are involved in at least one extracurricular activity are significantly more likely to feel connected to school and graduate on time. The challenge: pick at least ONE thing you've never done before and commit to trying it in the first semester. It doesn't have to be the thing you stick with forever — it just has to get you in the door.

I commit to trying: _____

Why I chose it: _____

When sign-ups/try-outs happen: _____

Someone I will do it with (or go alone — that's brave too): _____

— EXIT TICKET · Lesson 5.2: Getting Involved at TRHS

How confident do you feel about getting involved at TRHS? (1 = not confident at all, 5 = very confident). Explain what would help you feel more confident.

1 Not at all	2	3 Somewhat	4	5 Absolutely
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ANTICIPATION

If Registration Were TODAY

Without looking at anything — write the 7 courses you would register for if it were due today:

P1: _____ P2: _____ P3: _____

P4: _____ P5: _____ P6: _____ P7: _____

How confident do you feel about these choices? (circle) 1 — 2 — 3 — 4 — 5

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	9 min	6 min	7 min	15 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 5.3 — Finalizing My Fall Schedule · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Transcript	<i>Etymology: Latin transcribere (to copy over) — trans (across) + scribere (to write)</i>	Your permanent academic record — every course, every grade, every credit, from 9th grade through graduation.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 5.3 · Reading: Choosing Well: Course Selection, Alternates, and the Art of Planning Ahead

Source: Adapted from TRHS course registration guidance and college admissions research

■ Listen: reading_EN_5.3.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

In December of your 8th grade year, you will submit your course registration for 9th grade at Two Rivers. This registration is considered final. That phrase carries significant weight: unlike middle school, where schedule changes are relatively common, high school course selections are used to determine how many sections to run, how many teachers to assign, and which rooms to book. Once those decisions are made, the system cannot easily accommodate individual changes. This is not designed to punish students — it is the reality of running a school of hundreds of students with limited resources.

This is why the planning you are doing right now matters. Every course you select should be deliberate. Can you articulate why you chose each course? Does your selection align with your interests, your career direction, and your academic strengths? Have you checked the prerequisites? Have you considered whether you are taking on too much in one semester, or too little?

You are also required to identify alternate course selections — second choices for each elective slot, in case your first choice is not available due to scheduling conflicts or enrollment limits. Alternates are not an afterthought: they are legitimate choices, treated equally with your primary selections. If you have not thought seriously about your alternates, you may end up in a course by default that does not serve your goals. Treat your alternates the way you treat your first choices — with intention.

College admissions research offers a useful perspective on course selection: admissions counselors at four-year universities consistently say they would rather see a student who challenged themselves and earned a B than one who took easy courses and earned an A. This does not mean you should overload yourself with AP courses in 9th grade — that approach backfires more often than it succeeds. It means you should select courses at the appropriate level of challenge for who you are right now, with room to grow over four years.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. Why is the 9th grade course registration considered final at Two Rivers? What is the reasoning behind this policy?

2. What are 'alternate course selections' and why are they important? What is the risk of not taking alternates seriously?

3. What do college admissions counselors say about taking challenging courses vs. easy courses? What is the implication for your planning?

4. The reading says every course selection should be 'deliberate.' Evaluate your own draft schedule from Lesson 4.2. Can you articulate why you chose each course? Revise or defend each choice.

5. Write your finalized 9th grade course selection as if you were submitting it to a school counselor. Include: course name, reason for choosing it, and one alternate for each elective. Make it as specific and thoughtful as possible.

"The Alternate"

■ Listen: story_EN_5.3.m4a

The registration form had an alternate line for every elective. Jordan had not filled in any of the alternate lines.

"What happens if you don't fill them in?" he asked Maya.

"They assign you something."

"Assign me what?"

"Whatever's open."

He looked at the blank lines. "So I could end up in something random."

"Yes."

"Why didn't anyone tell me that."

"It says it on the form."

He looked at the form. It did say it. He hadn't read the instructions.

Eli had filled in alternates but not thought hard about them. His alternate for Intro to Technology was Study Hall. He'd written it because Study Hall wasn't a real choice — it was just what you put when you didn't know.

"Is Study Hall an actual option?" he asked Maya.

"It's a choice. Not usually a good one."

"Why not?"

"Because if you end up in it, it means you got placed out of what you actually wanted, and now you have an open period with no structure."

Eli erased it. He thought about what he actually wanted as a backup.

"If I can't get into Transportation CAPS," he said slowly, "I'd want the Intro to Engineering class. That's still in the same direction."

"Write that," Maya said.

He wrote it. It was a better answer. It was also the first time he'd said out loud that he might not get his first choice — and that there was a plan for that.

Jordan was still staring at his blank alternate lines.

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Jordan didn't read the instructions on the form and might end up with a random placement. How does this connect to what we've learned about planning ahead versus reacting?

2. Eli puts 'Study Hall' as an alternate because it's easy to write. What's wrong with that as a planning strategy?

3. Why is it important that Eli's alternate (Intro to Engineering) is 'still in the same direction'? What does that suggest about how to choose an alternate?

4. If your first-choice elective is unavailable, what would your real alternate be — and why? Does it still connect to something you care about?

Unit 5 · Lesson 5.3 — Finalizing My Fall Schedule

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Review and finalize their mock 9th grade course schedule.
- Identify 2–3 alternate course selections in case first choices are unavailable.
- Write a brief course rationale explaining their scheduling choices.

Your Schedule is Your Foundation

The courses you take in 9th grade are the foundation of your high school transcript. They determine which courses you can take in 10th grade (because of prerequisites), how your GPA starts, and how your interests develop. At TRHS, all registrations are considered final after submission — so it is critical to think carefully about your choices now. You must also identify alternate courses in case your first choice is unavailable. This is not a punishment — it's smart planning.

Finalize & Justify Your Schedule

Complete the final schedule below. For each course choice, write ONE sentence explaining why you chose it. Then identify an alternate for each elective slot.

Period	Course Choice	Why I chose it	Alternate
Period 1			
Period 2			
Period 3			
Period 4			
Period 5			
Period 6			
Period 7			

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 5.3: Finalizing My Fall Schedule

3 courses I am taking in 9th grade and why I chose each:

2 things I am doing to prepare for my most challenging course:

1 alternate course I identified and why:

REVIEW

What I Still Want to Know

Think about everything we've covered in Warrior Prep this semester.

Write the ONE question about high school that you still haven't gotten a clear answer to. Make it specific and story-inviting — not a yes/no question:

My panel question:

Write Your Response — Use complete sentences.

Today's 50-Minute Plan

5 min	3 min	8 min	5 min	4 min	25 min	5 min
Bell Ringer	Intro	Reading	Questions	Content	Activity	Exit Ticket

Lesson 5.4 — TRHS Student Panel · Cornell Notes

Name: _____

Date: _____

Period: _____

Word Focus: Concurrent Enrollment (CE)	<i>Etymology: Latin concurrere (to run together) + Latin enrollare (to enter on a roll/list)</i>	A high school course that also earns college credit — you start building your college transcript while still in high school.
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[illegible]

SUMMARY — Write the main ideas in your own words (complete AFTER the lesson, without looking):

Lesson 5.4 · Reading: The Art of Asking Good Questions

Source: Adapted from research on dialogue, mentorship, and knowledge transfer

■ Listen: reading_EN_5.4.m4a

As you read: use your annotation symbols (* = important · ? = question · ! = surprising · → = connection · circle = vocab)

You are about to have a rare opportunity: direct access to students who have already done what you are about to do. They have survived the first weeks of 9th grade. They have learned which habits worked and which backfired. They have navigated the social landscape of Two Rivers, figured out how to manage a harder workload, and formed opinions — through experience — about what they wish they had known. The quality of what you learn from them depends almost entirely on the quality of the questions you ask.

Research on mentorship and knowledge transfer consistently shows that generic questions produce generic answers. 'What is high school like?' will get you 'It's different.' 'What's harder than you expected and how did you deal with it?' will get you a story. Stories are how humans transmit real knowledge. When a panelist tells you about the time they bombed their first Geometry test and had to figure out how to recover, they are giving you a map you can actually use.

The best questions share a few qualities. They are specific — they name a situation, a course, or a challenge rather than asking about 'high school in general.' They invite stories rather than opinions — 'Tell me about a time when...' almost always produces more useful answers than 'What do you think about...'. They are honest — they reflect something you genuinely want to know, not something you think sounds impressive. And they follow up — if an answer is interesting, you ask 'Can you say more about that?' rather than moving on.

You have prepared for this panel by reading, writing, planning, and thinking carefully about your 9th grade year. Now your job is to listen actively: take notes on what surprises you, what confirms what you already thought, and what makes you want to ask a follow-up. Active listening — not passive hearing — turns a conversation into a resource you can return to.

Reading Comprehension Questions

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use evidence from the reading.

1. What is the difference between a generic question and a specific question? Give an example of each using the student panel as context.

2. Why do 'story-inviting' questions produce better answers than 'opinion' questions? Can you think of a question that invites a story vs. one that invites an opinion?

3. The reading says the best questions are 'honest' — meaning they reflect something you genuinely want to know. Write three questions that are genuinely honest for you right now about starting high school.

4. What is active listening and how is it different from passive hearing? What will you do during the panel to listen actively?

5. After the panel: Write the most important thing you heard. What did a panelist say that surprised you, confirmed your thinking, or changed how you are thinking about 9th grade?

"The Question Worth Asking"

■ Listen: story_EN_5.4.m4a

The student panel was tomorrow. Their teacher had asked them to each prepare three questions.

Jordan had written: *What's your favorite class?* and *Is high school hard?* He was working on the third.

Maya had written six. She'd crossed out four of them for being too general.

Priya had written one. She'd been working on it for thirty minutes. It said:

Was there a moment in 9th grade where you felt like you were doing it wrong — and what did you do?

Jordan read it over her shoulder. "That's a good one."

"It's too personal."

"That's what makes it good."

She read it again. She'd written it because she wanted the real answer. Not the answer a high schooler gives in a presentation. The real one.

Eli had written: *What do you wish someone had told you before 9th grade started?*

"That's the same idea," Maya said, pointing. "You both want the honest version."

"What's yours?" Jordan asked her.

She showed him. *How do you handle it when a course is harder than you expected and dropping it isn't an option?*

"Maya. That's a very specific question."

"I have a very specific fear."

A quiet moment. Four people with four questions, all of which were actually about the same thing: what happens when it gets hard and you have to stay anyway.

Jordan looked at his two questions. "These are bad," he said.

"They're conversation starters," Priya said. "Not bad ones."

"They're not what I actually want to know."

"What do you actually want to know?"

He thought about it honestly. About the stack on his desk. About the grade portal. About all the things he'd meant to do and hadn't.

"I want to know if any of it gets easier," he said. "Or if you just get better at it."

Priya looked at him. "Write that," she said. "That's the real question."

Discussion Questions

Discuss with your partner or small group. Then write your best thinking below.

1. Priya's question is 'too personal' — but Jordan says that's what makes it good. Who is right, and what makes a panel question worth asking?

2. Maya, Priya, and Eli's questions are all different ways of asking the same thing. What is that shared underlying question?

3. Jordan realizes his first two questions aren't what he actually wants to know. What does it mean to ask an honest question — and why is that harder than it sounds?

4. Write the one question you genuinely want to ask the student panel — the honest one, not the one that sounds impressive. What's stopping you from asking it?

Learning Objectives — By the end of this lesson you will be able to:

- Generate thoughtful, specific questions for current TRHS students.
- Actively listen and take notes during the student panel.
- Synthesize panel insights into personal action steps for 9th grade.

Preparing Your Questions

Great questions lead to great answers. Before the panel begins, write down at least FIVE questions you genuinely want answered by current Two Rivers students. Think about: academics, social life, activities, what surprised them, what they wish they had known, what advice they have for you. The best questions are specific, not generic. 'What's high school like?' will get a vague answer. 'What did you do when you got your first bad grade?' will get a real one.

Question 1:

Question 2:

Question 3:

Question 4:

Question 5:

Panel Notes

Use this space to take notes during the student panel. Write the speaker's name (or 'Student A, B, C...') and the key ideas you want to remember.

⇒ EXIT TICKET · Lesson 5.4: TRHS Student Panel

Directions: Write a letter (at least two paragraphs) to an 8th grader who is about to take Warrior Prep next year. Tell them: what you learned in this course, what you would do differently if you could go back, your top three pieces of advice for transitioning to Two Rivers, and what you are most looking forward to in 9th grade.